

Free Indeed!

St. Joseph the All-Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

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Contact Info.....	1
A Word from Fr Seraphim	2
NB:Gleanings for the Holy Fathers.....	3
Homily on the Sunday of the Dread Judgment by St. John of Shanghai and San Francisco.....	4
Homily of St. Tikhon, Patriarch of Moscow and Apostle to America, given on the Sunday of the Triumph of Orthodoxy, 1903, in the Cathedral in San Francisco.	6
The Cross, Preserver of the Universe. -St John of Shanghai & San Francisco.....	7
On the Inevitability of Suffering: A Sermon on the Cross	7
The Cross.....	9
A true story of the power of the Cross:	10
Statement of Archbishop Peter on the Continuing War in Ukraine	10
Statement of the Diocesan Council of the Mid-American Diocese	11
A Lenten Address from Bishop Irenei on the Diocese's Response to the Situation in Ukraine.....	11
Archbishop Mark. Letter about the war in Ukraine	12
Archimandrite Zacharias Zacharou answering a question concerning the current situation in the world :	13
About the Spirit of Our Time, by Patriarch Pavle.....	13
Simple Prayer	13
Saint Ascension" answers prayers ... if you are holy.....	14
May 2, Saint Boris-Michael, Tsar of Bulgaria. We must be flexible *and* inflexible.....	14
Pentecost is a different kind of feast.	14
We always do what we *want* to do. And Running with wolves.....	15
It's absolutely impossible to become good unless we know that we are bad.	16
Excerpts from the kneeling prayers	16
The Ever-Memorable Metropolitan Hilarion	17
Sin is our only adversary. Sin causes all evils.	17
HOMILY ON THE SUNDAY OF THE PARALYTIC ON DIVINE PUNISHMENT	18

http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-022_2022-06-18.doc

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Note: With God helping us, we will send many newsletters to those we minister to in prison. We aim to send a newsletter at least twice each month. This is the 22nd sent to 74 souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at <http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

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A Word from Fr Seraphim

It is been a very long time we have sent you a newsletter. I am the editor of the newsletter and the one who prints it, stuffs the envelopes, etc. In the time that we have not been sending you a newsletter I have written two partial newsletters. That doesn't make much sense, does it? Sometimes I think I do things that don't make sense.

So, I am sending this newsletter which is kind of dated, because I want to get something to you, but it will have a little bit of new material. I am very aware that people in prison can feel abandoned and forgotten. We were sending you a very hefty newsletter regularly last year and then the wheels fell off. I'm not sure exactly why this happened. I don't have any excuses for it. It's a time management problem, and sin management problem. During this time, I've actually been writing a lot and been very busy with prison ministry and I pray for everybody on prison ministry diptychs every single day. But you don't see that, and for most of you that don't know me personally, the only indication that I'm interested in you is a regular newsletter.

I apologize to all of you deeply if any of you felt abandoned. Whether it's in the so-called "free world" which is not really free unless we have the Holy Spirit abiding in us and follow the commandments of God and have a deep faith in Christ, or in the prison world, life does go on, and sometimes it seems like it's a fast flowing river. It carries us where it wills if we don't of our own will struggle against the current.

I've learned a few things in my 27 years and counting in the priesthood and 42 years and counting of being an Orthodox Christian. I've learned that the most important activity that we can have in this life is an activity that no one else sees, except God. It is the activity of prayer and fasting, reading of holy texts, and doing prostrations for others. It is our primary work. I hope that you are doing the primary work, even if you, like me, am not keeping up on your correspondence as you should. People need letters and phone calls, but they especially need prayer. I am not letting you down in prayer.

Fr David and I are doing substantially different tasks. He sees many of you in prison and I have not yet gone to a prison since the p(l)andemic began. I go to the Marshall parole house twice a month, and it's longer than most prison trips. He visits several prisons a month. I tried to visit the Hughes unit and a woman's prison in the same city recently but they were locked down because someone had escaped from the prison. So of course, what are they going to do? They are going to try to catch a fly with a blow torch. All the prisoners in Gatesville were locked down, even though the prisoner escaped when he was out of prison and on a bus. You all know that that doesn't make much sense.

It is impossible for Fr David or myself to stress too much to how important it is that you have an inner life. Cultivate an inner life! If you have not prayed with intensity on a given day, you have wasted that day. If you've read inconsequential things that day and not the holy Scriptures and the Psalter and the lives of the saints, in any combination, you've wasted that day. Prison life, just like life in the "free world" can drone on and put us to sleep. We are Christians! We should not sleep!

I am not sleeping because I have been praying for you. However, it just seems like there is not enough hours in the day. Someone recently just told me: "I know you're busy and I don't want to take up too much of your time." And I wrote to her and told her that: "I am indeed very busy. I'm very busy with sinning. It takes up so much time that I do not do other things that are more needful."

Perhaps you would characterize yourself that way. I hope very much that you do. If you know anything about our Orthodox prayers, you would surely see that they are constantly admitting that we are sinners and that

we are incapable of doing anything without God helping us. Let's, all of us, beg God to help us in everything that we do but especially, first and foremost, that we have an inner life. From that inner life comes the energy to do the things that are in our outer life.

I hope very much that all of you pray for those who minister to you. How many of you are doing this? Every single one of you, whether you know us personally or not, should be praying for Fr David and for me, Fr Seraphim. We are not worthy of your prayers, but you must pray. Without prayer, we can do nothing.

I noticed something about people in prison and the Orthodox faith, and how they practice the Orthodox faith when they get out of prison. You're in a bubble right now. There a lot of things that are hard about prison, but there also some things that are easier.

It's very easy to be zealous and "Orthodox" in prison without really understanding how hard this is. One of our visits to you is a service of no more than two hours, and much of that is taken up by introductions and talking and the chaplain taking attendance, and people lounging in their seats. This is not a real picture of what Orthodox life is.

Many of you do not fast because you excuse yourself because, after all, you're in prison and cannot choose the food that you are served. That is a serious mistake! There are definitely ways to fast in prison, if not absolutely rigidly according to the canons, according to the spirit of them. When you get out of prison, there will be 30 fast-food restaurants within a few miles of where you live. In my experience, most Orthodox prisoners, upon release from prison, will frequently ignore the fasts of the church or will be very inconsistent with them because of the siren song of those restaurants.

If you are where there is a good Orthodox parish, one that values prayer, you will soon discover that it's not that easy to go to Saturday vigil and pay attention for three hours. You will discover that not that easy to say your communion prayers and have a quiet Saturday night to prepare for communion the next day.

You will find that it's not that easy to guard your mind when you have a taskmaster that you can hold in your hand that can deliver you any distracting thing at any time. That taskmaster can deliver you useless conversations, religious trivia, and porn any time of the day or night. It may even deliver you quotes from Orthodox fathers and pious sayings and religious memes, but if you are not living according to those pious sayings by praying in your closet, they will be worthless to you. You will discover that the free world is not free unless you are free in your heart. The only way to obtain this freedom is to consider yourself to be a slave to God.

By your prayers, Fr David will continue to have the energy to do all the visits he does, and the next newsletter will come out to you in a timely way.

I told you, above, that I go to the parole house in Marshall, twice a month. The idea is that anyone, no matter what their sentence, can parole to this house. Right now, we can only accept one person at a time. Hopefully, each person can transition into the community and we can build a parish there. We want to have those in the house and others that have transitioned out of the house but still live in the area to live as a community, with at least nightly prayer together. We had a prisoner come to the house but he wasn't interested in community life. He was interested in doing what he wanted to do. Now we are in a kind of doldrums. We have all the expenses of the house, and are waiting to find someone who is Orthodox and dedicated to living a sacrificial community life. I personally love going to the Marshall house twice a month, but we are all waiting for the house to actually serve the purpose that we originally bought it for. We'll see what God allows.

May God grant you a profitable Apostles fast. May God bless you and help you in all things.

Please forgive any typos. I have proofread, but I am terrible at it, and my wife is out of town, and I want to get this letter out FINALLY! Priest Seraphim

NB:Gleanings for the Holy Fathers

"NB" is an abbreviation for the fancy Latin phrase: "note well." It is undoubtedly important to "note well" holy things. This abbreviation is used in a lot of social media.

"God is found in our toil. Without toil, nothing is accomplished. I say this out of years of experience, even though I am unworthy and sinful. I have seen God in toil. When a person avoids labor, avoids difficulties, saying "Oh, I can't go there," and "Oh, I can't do that," he becomes selfish and protects himself. Let us not contradict..." Therefore, let us force ourselves. Let us watch the clock so we do not miss an hour or a minute to work for God..."

+Gerondissa Makrina Vassopoulou from Homily 33 - Words of the Heart.

ST PORPHYRIOS ON PRAYING FOR OTHERS

There's an invisible life, the life of the soul. It's very powerful and can affect others, even if they're thousands of miles away. If we pray with love for someone, no matter how far away we are, goodness is transmitted.

St Porphyrios the Kapsokalyvite.

If you are remembering evil against someone, then pray for him; and as you remove through prayer the pain of the remembrance of the evil he has done, you will stop the advance of the passion. And when you have attained brotherly love and love for mankind, you will completely cast this passion out of your soul. Then when someone else does evil to you, be affectionate and humble toward him, and treat him kindly, and you will deliver him from this passion." St. Maximos the Confessor. Four Hundred Texts on Love 3.90

"Very often it happens that we are blackened, humiliated, despised or hurt, completely undeserved if we look at it from a worldly point of view. But God allows all this as a compensation for our old sins, so that we may forgive others, receive forgiveness from God for all the injustice and sins we have ever committed to humans. Therefore, we should rejoice, not mourn in such sorrows, but in fact, we are insolent and bitter without measure. Forgive us Lord! I think we should forgive our neighbors, not only to have our sins forgiven, but with full consciousness that these people do evil not at their will, but tempted by demons—they know not what they do (John 23:24)."

- Schemaarchimandrite Ilius Nozdryn

Don't give in to panic. Cowards are of use to no one. God looks at a person's situation and helps him. We have to remain cold-blooded and use our brains. No matter what happens, we must continue to pray, think and act. It's best to always stand up to a difficult situation using spiritual means. However, that spiritual boldness which is born of holiness and striving towards God is missing today, as is the natural boldness needed in order not to turn coward in the face of danger.

St. Paisios of Mount Athos

The Divine Scripture says: 'God said to Adam: Adam, where art thou?' (Gen. 3:9). Why did the Creator of all things say this? Of course, it was in order to dispose Adam to come to his senses, to acknowledge his sin and repent. This is why He said, "Adam, where art thou?" As it were he said, "Adam, enter into yourself, acknowledge your nakedness and understand what a garment and what a glory you have lost. Adam where are you?"

-Venerable Symeon the New Theologian

The First-Created man p.108

Above all let us be convinced that nothing can happen to us apart from the providence of God.-Dorotheos of Gaza Discourses and Sayings

God is merciful by nature and always provides for our good and, when we ask Him for something, He will provide it, as long as it is for our good. Whatever is necessary for the salvation of our soul and for the maintenance of our physical existence, God will provide it in abundance, and we'll have His blessing. Whatever He deprives us of, either to test us or to protect us, we accept with joy as well as with thoughtfulness, as it is for our benefit. -Elder Paisios of Mount Athos Spiritual Counsels Vol. II Spiritual Awakening 318

To an Orthodox, Elder St Paisios said... Cultivate your devoutness and your modesty as much as you can. This will help you receive the Grace of God. For, if someone is devout and spiritually modest and humble too, he can expect to receive divine Grace. If he has no devoutness and no humility, the Grace of God does not come to him. -Elder Paisios of Mount Athos. Spiritual Counsels Vol. II Spiritual Awakening p.170

ORTHODOX GREAT LENT: ATTAIN SPIRITUAL FREEDOM, EXCEL, ASCEND, ARISE

FASTING — THE FIRST COMMANDMENT BROKEN, WE WERE BANISHED FROM PARADISE

"Fasting is as old as humanity: it was legislated in Paradise. It was the first command that Adam received: You shall not eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. You shall not eat legislates fasting and self-control. If Eve had fasted from the tree, we would not need this fasting now. For those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick. We have been injured by sin; let us be healed by repentance. But repentance is futile without fasting. . . Now the manner of life in Paradise is an image of fasting, not only insofar as man, sharing the life of the angels, achieved likeness to them by being content with little, but also because those who lived in Paradise had still not dreamt up what humans later discovered through their inventiveness [i.e., "civilization"]: there was still no drinking of wine, still no animal sacrifices, not to mention whatever else beclouds the human mind. It is because we did not fast that we were banished from Paradise. So let us fast that we may return to it. . . do not take the serpent as your advisor, who suggests that you eat out of regard for the flesh." — St. Basil the Great, On Fasting and Feasts [Popular Patristic Series Book 50] Kindle Locations 1293-1311. St Vladimir's Seminary Press. Kindle Edition)

BY BREAKING THE FAST, PARADISE LOSS; BY KEEPING THE FAST, PARADISE OPENED.

"And when the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and that it was pleasant to the eyes, and a tree to be desired to make one wise, she took of the fruit thereof, and did eat, and gave also unto her husband with her; and he did eat." (Genesis 3:6) "...Adam chose the treason of the serpent, the originator of evil, in preference to God's commandment and counsel, and broke the decreed fast. Instead of eternal life he received

death and instead of the place of unsullied joy he received this sinful place full of passions and misfortunes, or rather, he was sentenced to Hades and nether darkness. Our nature would have stayed in the infernal regions below the lurking places of the serpent who initially beguiled it, had not Christ come. He started off by fasting (cf. Mk. 1:13) and in the end abolished the serpent's tyranny, set us free and brought us back to life." — St. Gregory Palamas

"Before all else, ensure that he, whom your daughters chooses as her companion for life, keeps the fast. If he does not, then he is not a Christian, whatever he may consider himself to be." — St. Seraphim of Sarov

"Many human activities, good in themselves, are not good because of the motive for which they are done. For example, fasting and vigils, prayer and psalmody, acts of charity and hospitality are by nature good, but when performed for the sake of self-esteem they are not good." — St. Maximos the Confessor, Four Hundred Texts on Love 2.35, The Philokalia: The Complete Text (Vol. 2)

"Fasting, prayer, alms, and every other good Christian deed is good in itself, but the purpose of the Christian life consists not only in the

fulfillment of one or another of them. The true purpose of our Christian life is the acquisition of the Holy Spirit of God. But fasting, prayer, alms and every good deed done FOR THE SAKE OF CHRIST is a means to the attainment of the Holy Spirit. Note that only good deeds done for the sake of Christ bear the fruit of the Holy Spirit. Everything else that is not done for the sake of Christ, even if it is good, does not bring us a reward in the life to come, nor does it bring the grace of God in this life. This is why our Lord Jesus Christ said, 'Whoever gathereth not with me scattereth' (Matt. 12:30)." — St. Seraphim of Sarov, Conversation on the Aim of the Christian Life

"The soul that really loves God and Christ, though it may do ten thousand righteousnesses, esteems itself as having wrought nothing, by reason of its insatiable aspiration after God. Though it should exhaust the body with fastings, with watchings, its attitude towards the virtues is as if it had not yet even begun to labor for them." — St. Macarius the Great

Homily on the Sunday of the Dread Judgment by St. John of Shanghai and San Francisco.

Today Is The Sunday of the Dread Judgment, and it is natural for us to speak of the Dread Judgment and of the signs of the end of the world. No one knows that day; only God the Father knows; but the signs of its approach are given in the Gospel and in the Revelation [Apocalypse] of the holy Apostle John the Theologian. Revelation speaks of the events at the end of the world and of the Dread Judgment principally in images and in a concealed manner; but the Holy Fathers have explained it, and there is an authentic Church tradition that speaks to us both about the signs of the approach of the end of the world and about the Dread Judgment.

Before the end of life on earth there will be confusion, wars, civil strife, famine, and earthquakes. Men will suffer from fear; they will expire from the expectation of calamities. There will be no life, no joy of life, but a tormenting state of falling away from life. There will be a falling away not only from life, but from faith as well: when the Son of Man cometh, shall He find faith on the earth? (Luke 18:8).

Men will become proud and ungrateful, denying the Divine Law: together with a falling away from life there will be also a dearth of moral life.

There will be an exhaustion of good, and a growth of evil. The holy Apostle John the Theologian, in his divinely-inspired work, the Revelation, also speaks of this time. He himself says that he "was in the Spirit," which means that the Holy Spirit Himself was in him when the fate of the Church and the world was revealed to him in various images, and that is why it is God's Revelation.

He represents the fate of the Church in the image of a woman who, in those times, hides in the wilderness: she does not show herself in public life, just as in Russia today.

Those forces that are preparing the appearance of Antichrist will have a leading significance in public life. Antichrist will be a man and not the devil incarnate. "Ann" is a word meaning "old," or it means "in place of" or "against." That man wants to be in place of Christ, to occupy His place and possess that which Christ ought to possess. He wants to possess the same attraction and authority over the whole world.

And he will receive that authority before his own destruction and that of the whole world. He will have a helper, a Magus, who, by the power of false miracles, will fulfill his will and kill those that do not recognize the authority of Antichrist. Before the destruction of Antichrist, two righteous men will appear who will denounce him. The Magus will kill them and their

bodies will lie unburied for three days, and Antichrist and all his servants will rejoice exceedingly. Then suddenly, those righteous men will resurrect, and the whole army of Antichrist will be in confusion and horror, and the Antichrist himself will suddenly fall dead, slain by the power of the Spirit.

But what is known about this man, Antichrist? His precise ancestry is unknown. His father is completely unknown, while his mother is a defiled, pretended virgin. He will be a Jew from the tribe of Dan. There is an indication of this, in that Jacob, when dying, said that [Dan], in his posterity, would be a serpent by the way... biting the heel of the horse (and the rider shall fall backward) (Gen. 49:17). This is a figurative indication that he will act with craftiness and evil.

In Revelation, John the Theologian speaks of the salvation of the sons of Israel, that before the end of the world a multitude of Jews will be converted to Christ; but the tribe of Dan is not included in the enumeration of the tribes that are saved.

Antichrist will be very intelligent and gifted with the ability to deal with people. He will be charming and affectionate.

The philosopher Vladimir Soloviev worked extensively on this subject in order to present the advent and the personality of Antichrist. He made careful use of all relevant materials, not only Patristic, but also Muslim, and produced a very striking picture.

Before the advent of Antichrist, his appearance is already being prepared in the world. "The mystery is already at work" (cf. II Thess. 2:7), and the forces preparing his appearance struggle above all against lawful royal authority. The holy Apostle Paul says that Antichrist cannot appear until "he that restrains" is removed. John Chrysostom explains that "he that restrains" is the lawful, godly authority.

Such an authority struggles with evil. The "mystery" working in the world does not want this; it does not want an authority that wars against evil; on the contrary, it wants an authority of iniquity, and when it succeeds in bringing this about, then nothing will stand in the way of the coming of Antichrist. He will be not only intelligent and charming: he will be compassionate, he will be charitable and do good, for the sake of consolidating his power. And when he will have strengthened it sufficiently, so that the whole world acknowledges him, then he will show his real face.

He will choose Jerusalem as his capital, because it was here that the Saviour revealed His Divine teaching and His Person, and the whole world was called to the blessedness of goodness and salvation. But the world did

not accept Christ and crucified Him in Jerusalem; while under Antichrist, Jerusalem will become the capital of the world that has recognized the authority of Antichrist.

Once having attained the summit of power, Antichrist will demand that men acknowledge his attainment as something to which no other earthly power and no other man could possibly attain, and he will demand that men bow down to him as to a superior being, a god.

Soloviev describes well the character of his activity as Supreme Ruler. He will do what pleases men, on the condition that they recognize his Supreme Authority. He will let the Church function, and allow her to hold Divine services, he will promise to build magnificent temples—provided he is recognized as the "Supreme Being" and that he is worshipped. He will have a personal hatred for Christ. He will live by this hatred and will rejoice at seeing men apostatize from Christ and the Church. There will be a mass falling away from the faith; even many bishops will betray the faith, justifying themselves by pointing to the splendid position of the Church.

A search for compromise will be the characteristic disposition of men. Straightforwardness of confession will vanish. Men will cleverly justify their fall, and an endearing evil will support such a general disposition. Men will grow accustomed to apostasy from the truth and to the sweetness of compromise and sin.

Antichrist will allow men everything, if only they "fall down and worship him." This is not something new. The Roman emperors were similarly prepared to grant the Christians freedom, if only they recognized [the emperor's] divinity and divine supreme authority; they martyred Christians only because they professed: "Worship God Alone and serve Him Alone."

The whole world will submit to him, and then he will reveal his hatred for Christ and Christianity. Saint John the Theologian says that all who worship him will have a mark on their forehead and right hand. It is not clear whether this will be an actual mark on the body, or if this is a figurative expression of the fact that men will acknowledge in their minds the necessity of worshipping Antichrist, as well as submit their wills to him. And when the whole world manifests such a complete submission—of both will and conscience—then the two righteous men [already] mentioned will appear and will fearlessly preach the faith and expose Antichrist.

Holy Scripture says that before the coming of the Saviour two "lamps," will appear, two "burning olive trees," "two righteous men." Antichrist will kill them by the power of the Magus. Who are these men? According to Church tradition, these are the two righteous who never tasted of death: the Prophet Elias and the Prophet Enoch. There is a prophecy that these saints, who had not tasted of death, will taste it for three days; but after three days they will resurrect.

Their death will be a great joy for Antichrist and his servants. Their rising three days later will bring them unspeakable horror, terror and confusion. And then will come the end of the world.

The Apostle Peter says that the first world was created out of water and perished by water. "Out of water" is also an image of the chaos of the physical mass, while "perished by water" is [an image] of the Flood. And now the world is reserved unto fire.....The earth also and the works that are therein shall be burned up (II Peter 3:7-10). All the elements will melt. This present world will perish in a single instant. In an instant everything will change.

And the sign of the Son of God will appear, that is, the sign of the Cross. The whole world, having willingly submitted to Antichrist, "will break out in lamentation," Everything is finished. Antichrist is slain. The end of his kingdom, the end of the war with Christ. The end, and accountability for one's whole life, an account to the True God.

Then, from the mountains of Palestine, the Ark of the Covenant will appear. The Prophet Jeremiah hid the Ark and the Holy Fire in a deep well.

When they took water from that well, it burst into flame. But the Ark itself they did not find.

When we look at life today, those able to see, see that everything foretold about the end of the world is being fulfilled.

Who then is this man — Antichrist? Saint John the Theologian figuratively gives him the name 666; but all attempts to understand this designation have been futile.

The life of the contemporary world gives us a fairly clear understanding of the possibility of the world burning up, when all the elements shall melt with fervent heat. Atomic fission gives us that understanding.

The end of the world does not signify its annihilation, but its transformation. Everything will be changed, suddenly, in the twinkling of an eye. The dead will resurrect in new bodies — their own, but renewed — just as the Saviour arose in His Body, and on it were the traces of the wounds from the nails and the spear; but it possessed new properties, and in this respect, it was a new body. It is unclear whether this will be an altogether new body or that with which man was created.

And the Lord will appear on the clouds with glory. How will we see Him? With our spiritual eyes. Even now, at death, righteous people see that which other people around them do not see.

The trumpets will sound, loud and powerful. They will trumpet in men's souls, in their conscience. Everything in the human conscience will become clear.

The Prophet Daniel, speaking of the Dread Judgment, relates how the Ancient of Days, the judge, is on His throne, and before Him is a river of fire. Fire is a purifying element. Fire scorches sin, it burns it up, and woe also burns it up; if sin has become natural to a man, then it burns up the man himself as well.

That fire will flare up inside a man: on seeing the Cross, some will rejoice, while others will fall into despair, confusion, terror. In this way, men will immediately be separated. In the Gospel narrative, some stand to the right of the Judge, some to the left — their inner consciousness separated them. The very state of a man's soul casts him to one side or the other, to the right or to the left.

The more consciously and persistently a man strives toward God in his life, the greater will be his joy when he hears the words: "Come unto Me, ye blessed"; and conversely, those same words will call forth the fire of horror and torment on those who did not want Him, who fled or fought or blasphemed Him during their life.

The Dread Judgment knows no witnesses or charge-sheets. Everything is recorded in men's souls, and these records, these "books" are open. Everything becomes clear to all and to oneself, and the state of a man's soul assigns him to the right or to the left.

Some go to joy, others to horror.

When the "books" are open, it will become clear to all that the roots of all vices are in man's soul. Here is a drunkard, a fornicator; some may think that when the body dies the sin dies as well. No; the inclination was in the soul, and to the soul the sin was sweet.

And if [the soul] has not repented of that sin and has not become free of it, it will come to the Dread Judgment with the same desire for the sweetness of sin and will never satisfy its desire. In it will be the suffering of hatred and malice. This is the state of hell.

The "fiery Gehenna" is the inner fire; this is the flame of vice, the flame of weakness and malice; and there will be [the] wailing and gnashing of teeth of impotent malice.

Homily of St. Tikhon, Patriarch of Moscow and Apostle to America, given on the Sunday of the Triumph of Orthodoxy, 1903, in the Cathedral in San Francisco.

This is a long post, but well worth the time it takes to read it. It's the Homily of St. Tikhon, Patriarch of Moscow and Apostle to America, given on the Sunday of the Triumph of Orthodoxy, 1903, in the Cathedral in San Francisco. You'll see that his words are prophetic, especially in terms of how closely they apply to Orthodox Christians living in the US today.

"This Sunday, Brethren, begins the week of Orthodoxy, or the week of the Triumph of Orthodoxy, because it is today that the Holy Orthodox Church solemnly recalls its victory over the Iconoclast heresy and other heresies and gratefully remembers all who fought for the Orthodox faith in word, writing, teaching, suffering, or godly living.

Keeping the day of Orthodoxy, Orthodox people ought to remember it is their sacred duty to stand firm in their Orthodox faith and carefully to keep it.

For us it is a precious treasure: in it we were born and raised; all the important events of our life are related to it, and it is ever ready to give us its help and blessing in all our needs and good undertakings, however unimportant they may seem. It supplies us with strength, good cheer and consolation, it heals, purifies and saves us.

The Orthodox faith is also dear to us because it is the Faith of our Fathers. For its sake the Apostles bore pain and labored; martyrs and preachers suffered for it; champions, who were like unto the saints, shed their tears and their blood; pastors and teachers fought for it; and our ancestors stood for it, whose legacy it was that to us it should be dearer than the pupil of our eyes.

And as to us, their descendants - do we preserve the Orthodox faith, do we keep to its Gospels? Of yore, the prophet Elijah, this great worker for the glory of God, complained that the Sons of Israel have abandoned the Testament of the Lord, leaning away from it towards the gods of the heathen. Yet the Lord revealed to His prophet, that amongst the Israelites there still were seven thousand people who have not knelt before Baal (3 Kings 19 LXX). Likewise, no doubt, in our days also there are some true followers of Christ. 'The Lord knoweth them that are His.' (2 Tim 2.19)

We do occasionally meet sons of the Church, who are obedient to Her decrees, who honor their spiritual pastors, love the Church of God and the beauty of its exterior, who are eager to attend to its Divine Service and to lead a good life, who recognize their human failings and sincerely repent of their sins.

But are there many such among us? Are there not more people, 'in whom the weeds of vanity and passion allow but little fruit to the influence of the Gospel, or even in whom it is altogether fruitless, who resist the truth of the Gospel, because of the increase of their sins, who renounce the gift of the Lord and repudiate the Grace of God'.

'I have given birth to sons and have glorified them, yet they deny Me,' said the Lord in the olden days concerning Israel. And today also there are many who were born, raised and glorified by the Lord in the Orthodox faith, yet who deny their faith, pay no attention to the teachings of the Church, do not keep its injunctions, do not listen to their spiritual pastors and remain cold towards the divine service and the Church of God.

How speedily some of us lose the Orthodox faith in this country of many creeds and tribes! They begin their apostasy with things, which in their eyes have but little importance. They judge it is 'old fashioned' and 'not accepted amongst educated people' to observe all such customs as: praying before and after meals, or even morning and night, to wear a cross, to keep icons in their houses and to keep church holidays and fast days. They even do not stop at this, but go further: they seldom go to church and sometimes not at all, as a man has to have some rest on a Sunday (...in a

saloon); they do not go to confession, they dispense with church marriage and delay baptizing their children.

And in this way their ties with Orthodox faith are broken! They remember the Church on their deathbed, and some don't even do that! To excuse their apostasy, they naively say: 'this is not the old country, this is America, and consequently it is impossible to observe all the demands of the Church.', as if the word of Christ is of use for the old country only and not for the whole world. As if the Orthodox faith is not the foundation of the world!

'Ah, sinful nation, a people laden with iniquity, a seed of evil doers, children that are corrupters: they have forsaken the Lord, they have provoked the Holy One of Israel into anger.' (Is 1.4)

If you do not preserve the Orthodox faith and the commandments of God, the least you can do is not to humiliate your hearts by inventing false excuses for your sins!

If you do not honor our customs, the least you can do is not to laugh at things you do not know or understand.

If you do not accept the motherly care of the Holy Orthodox Church, the least you can do is to confess you act wrongly, that you are sinning against the Church and behave like children!

If you do, the Orthodox Church may forgive you, like a loving mother, your coldness and slights, and will receive you back into her embrace, as if you were erring children.

Holding to the Orthodox faith, as to something holy, loving it with all their hearts and prizing it above all, Orthodox people ought, moreover, to endeavor to spread it amongst people of other creeds.

Christ the Savior has said that 'neither do men light a candle and put it under a bushel, but on a candle stick, and it giveth light unto all that are in the house.' (Mt 5.15)

The light of Orthodoxy was not lit to shine only on a small number of men. The Orthodox Church is universal; it remembers the words of its Founder: 'Go ye into the world, and preach the gospel to every creature' (Lk 16.15), 'go ye therefore and teach all nations' (Mt 28.19).

We ought to share our spiritual wealth, our truth, light and joy with others, who are deprived of these blessings, but often are seeking them and thirsting for them.

Once 'a vision appeared to Paul in the night, there stood a man from Macedonia and prayed him, saying, come over into Macedonia, and help us,' (Acts 16.9) after which the apostle started for this country to preach Christ. We also hear a similar inviting voice. We live surrounded by people of alien creeds; in the sea of other religions, our Church is a small island of salvation, towards which swim some of the people, plunged in the sea of life. 'Come, hurry, help,' we sometimes hear from the heathen of far Alaska, and oftener from those who are our brothers in blood and once were our brothers in faith also, the Uniates. 'Receive us into your community, give us one of your good pastors, send us a Priest that we might have the Divine Service performed for us of a holy day, help us to build a church, to start a school for our children, so that they do not lose in America their faith and nationality,' those are the wails we often hear, especially of late.

And are we to remain deaf and insensible? God save us from such a lack of sympathy. Otherwise, woe unto us, 'for we have taken away the key of knowledge, we entered not in ourselves, and them that were entering in we hindered.' (Lk 11.52)

But who is to work for the spread of the Orthodox faith, for the increase of the children of the Orthodox Church? Pastors and missionaries, you answer. You are right; but are they to be alone?

St. Paul wisely compares the Church of Christ to a body, and the life of a body is shared by all the members. So, it ought to be in the life of the Church also. 'The whole body fitly joined together and compacted by that which every joint supplieth, according to the effectual working in the measure of every part, maketh increase of the body unto the edifying of itself in love.' (Eph 4.16)

At the beginning, not only pastors alone suffered for the faith of Christ, but lay people also, men, women and even children. Heresies were fought against by lay people as well. Likewise, the spread of Christ's faith ought to be near and precious to the heart of every Christian. In this work every member of the Church ought to take a lively and heart-felt interest. This interest may show itself in personal preaching of the Gospel of Christ.

And to our great joy, we know of such examples amongst our lay brethren. In Sitka, members of the Indian brotherhood do missionary work amongst other inhabitants of their villages. And one zealous brother took a trip to a distant village (Kilisno), and helped the local Priest very much in shielding the simple and credulous children of the Orthodox Church against alien influences, by his own explanations and persuasions. Moreover, in many places of the United States, those who have left Uniatism to join Orthodoxy point out to their friends where the truth is to be found, and dispose them to enter the Orthodox Church.

Needless to say, it is not everybody among us who has the opportunity or the faculty to preach the gospel personally. And in view of this I shall indicate to you, Brethren, what every man can do for the spread of Orthodoxy and what he ought to do.

The Apostolic Epistles often disclose the fact, that when the Apostles went to distant places to preach, the faithful often helped them with their prayers and their offerings. Saint Paul sought this help of the Christians especially.

Consequently we can express the interests we take in the cause of the Gospel in praying to the Lord, that He should take this holy cause under His protection, that He should give its servants the strength to do their work worthily, that He should help them to conquer difficulties and dangers, which are part of the work, that He should not allow them to grow depressed or weaken in their zeal; that He should open the hearts of the

unbelieving for the hearing and acceptance of the Gospel of Christ, that He should impart to them the word of truth, that He should unite them to the Holy Catholic and Apostolic Church; that He should confirm, increase and pacify His Church, keeping it forever invincible, we pray for all this, but mostly with lips and but seldom with the heart.

Don't we often hear such remarks as these: 'what is the use of these special prayers for the newly initiated? They do not exist in our time, except, perhaps, in the out of the way places of America and Asia; let them pray for such where there are any; as to our country such prayers only needlessly prolong the service which is not short by any means, as it is.' Woe to our lack of wisdom! Woe to our carelessness and idleness!

Offering earnest prayers for the successful preaching of Christ, we can also show our interest by helping it materially. It was so in the primitive Church, and the Apostles lovingly accepted material help to the cause of the preaching, seeing in it an expression of Christian love and zeal.

In our days, these offerings are especially needed, because for the lack of them the work often comes to a dead stop. For the lack of them preachers cannot be sent out, or supported, churches cannot be built or schools founded, the needy amongst the newly converted cannot be helped. All this needs money and members of other religions always find a way of supplying it.

Perhaps, you will say, that these people are richer than ourselves. This is true enough, but great means are accumulated by small, and if everybody amongst us gave what he could towards this purpose, we also could raise considerable means. Accordingly, do not be ashamed of the smallness of your offering. If you have much, offer all you can, but do offer, do not lose the chance of helping the cause of the conversion of your neighbors to Christ, because by so doing, in the words of St. James, 'you shall save your own soul from death and shall hide a multitude of sins' (Jas 5.19-20).

Orthodox people! In celebrating the day of Orthodoxy, you must devote yourselves to the Orthodox faith not in word or tongue only, but indeed and in truth."

On the Inevitability of Suffering: A Sermon on the Cross

-New Hieromartyr John, Archbishop of Riga and Latvia, who, for his unyielding witness to the Truth suffered many persecutions and was burned alive by communist assassins in the night of October 12, 1934.

From that time, Jesus began to show to His disciples that it is necessary for Him to go away to Jerusalem, and to suffer many things from the elders and chief priests and scribes, and to be killed, and to be raised the third day. And Peter took Him to himself and began to rebuke Him, saying, 'May God be gracious to Thee, Lord; this in no wise shall be to Thee.' But He turned and said to Peter,

Get thee behind Me, Satan; thou art an offense to Me, for thou mindest not the things of God, but the things of men.

Mt. 16:21-23

This revelation of the Lord concerning the sufferings which awaited Him, struck His disciples like a thunderclap from a clear sky. Earlier, He had told them that His path was also their path: The servant is not greater than his master.

He who does not take up his cross and follow after Me is not worthy of Me.

Mt. 10:38

And in the lives of Christ's true disciples there is a time of suffering passion when each must enter his own Jerusalem, ascend his Golgotha and the fateful cross, and take up the fateful cup – even unto death.

Even the sons of this world each have their own Golgotha. Unforeseen and uninvited, suffering enters the house. You must suffer whether you like it or not. The bitter "must." This "must" is bitter even for the faithful disciple of Christ. And the cross of suffering frightens even him. In his soul is heard the voice of Peter: 'have mercy on yourself, do not let this happen, protect yourself.' And this is not surprising, for after all, the Great Sufferer Himself prayed:

If it be possible, take this cup from Me

Mt. 26:39; Mk. 14:36; Lk. 22:42.

This "must" is altogether necessary and we are powerless to stand against it.

From that time, Jesus began to show to His disciples that it is necessary for Him to go away to Jerusalem, and to suffer many things....

Mt. 16:21

If the way of the Lord leads to Jerusalem, if His fate is to be decided by the scribes, the Pharisees, the elders, then it is natural that He must suffer and be killed. This Jerusalem towards which Christ directed His steps is not

the Heavenly Jerusalem, but an earthly city filled with the spirit of this world, which had fallen away from its God, not recognizing, not comprehending the visitation of the Lord.

This is the same Jerusalem which, at the altar of the Lord, killed the prophets and stoned those who were sent to it [cf. Mt. 23:37; Lk. 11:47-51]. And the world, my brothers, even unto this day stands on that same foundation. Perhaps it does not have the same outward appearance. Nowadays they do not crucify people on crosses as they did Peter, nor are people stoned like Stephen. People have become too indifferent towards faith to suffer for its sake.

Our path is less rocky and whoever murmurs at the harshness and the evil of this world should know that he is far from suffering unto blood. Nevertheless, now as never before, the words of the Lord contain a sacred truth:

If ye were of the world, the world would love its own; but because ye are not of the world—but I chose you for Myself out of the world—therefore the world hateth you

Jn. 15:19

It cannot do otherwise.

The natural desire of man's heart is to live at peace with everyone. Many a youthful heart has decided to follow the path of reliance on oneself: 'I want to get along with everyone; I must not antagonize anyone.' But even the best-intentioned soon realize that this is impossible. Even the meekest lamb is sure to meet on his way a ferocious wolf that says: 'You are a thorn in my side.'

He who believes must confess his faith. He who desires to serve God in this world must act according to his faith. But every confession inevitably arouses antagonism and every action is sure to meet with hostility. To see that his honest persuasion and striving are not recognized by the world; that his good deeds are everywhere met with opposition; that there where he sows only love, he must reap evil – this is obviously very grievous to the follower of Christ. And he is often ready to ask, together with his Master: 'What evil has been done to you? Or how have I offended thee?' [from the hymns of Great and Holy Friday of Passion Week]. The truth which you proclaim and which you confess and which the world cannot gainsay, or the righteousness manifest in your life which silently reproaches the world, or the peace of the Lord written on your face which the world cannot forgive, or the heavenly other-worldliness of your behavior which shames and accuses their earthly way of life – this is how you have offended the world. And the world would sooner pardon you of ten vices and crimes which get you on a level with others, than forgive one good deed which elevates you above the rest. Why did Cain murder Abel? Because Cain's actions were evil and the actions of Abel were good and righteous [cf. 1 Jn. 3:12]. Why did the scribes and Pharisees condemn the Savior? Because He was Light and darkness cannot abide the light [cf. Jn 3:16-21].

Do not be astonished then, my dear brothers, if the world hates you. It is to be expected. This is nothing unusual. Do not let evil mockings and the vicious hatred of evil doers lead you astray. Go along the straight road with the name of the Lord, through the world which lies in evil and think in yourself "I must..." and the world cannot do otherwise. It would not be the world if it did not prefer the lies of its errors to truth; egoism to love; its laziness to zeal for God; worldly vanity to righteousness. I am not a disciple of Christ, not His soldier, if I do what is pleasing to everyone, if I go along the broad path together with the crowd instead of keeping to the narrow path where there are few travelers.

And so let us step forward in the name of the Lord with the conscious awareness that "I must."

There is another aspect to this "I must." When the Son of Man told His disciples that He must go to Jerusalem and there to suffer much and to die, He was aware that this was necessary even for Himself.

Because He was obedient unto death, even death on the cross, God raised Him up and gave Him a name above every name.

Phil. 2:8-9

If the Heavenly Father so willed that even His only-begotten Son would drink from the cup of suffering, is it for us sinners who are so imperfect to shun this cup of suffering, this school of suffering, when we are such a long way from perfection and still have so much to learn in order to become worthy disciples of the Great Sufferer?

Some think: 'How much more fervently and willingly I would serve my Lord if only my life's path were easier, if it were not so thickly strewn with sharp rocks.' In saying this, you yourself obviously do not know who and what you are, what is beneficial for you and what is harmful, what you need and what you do not need. It is true when they say that a man tolerates least of all his own well-being. Days of happiness, days of success, when everything goes according to one's own wishes – how many times have such days woven a fatal net which captures the soul? What dissoluteness grows on man's heart, like rust on the blade of an unused battle-sword, or like a garden which becomes overgrown if not tended by the gardener's shears. Tell me, O Christian, what preserves you from haughtiness which so easily penetrates even the strongest hearts, even the hearts of Christ's disciples? Is it not the cross of suffering? What humbles the passionate inclinations of the flesh which so quickly and easily spread in times of wellbeing and prosperity, like insects in a swamp on a sunny day? What teaches you to shun this uncleanness? Is it not the rod of misfortunes and sorrows? What arouses you from the sleep of self-assurance, lulled to sleep as we so easily are by times of happiness: Or what is more conducive to a routine of laziness than cloudless, carefree days of prosperity? At such times a storm can only be regarded as a blessing. What will draw you out of the dangerous state of insensibility? Will not sorrows? Will not illness? What tears us away from our worldly attachments, the love for the world and all that is in it? Is it not necessity and misfortunes? Do not trials teach us to take life more seriously? Do not sorrows teach us to be prepared for death? Wild brambles of the heart cannot be uprooted without the pruning shears of the Heavenly Gardener and the good fruit of truth and righteousness will not grow without the rain of tears and sorrows. Nowhere can true obedience be better tested than in the bearing of the bitter cup of sorrows, when one can only say:

...not my will, but Thine be done, Father

cf. Mt. 26:39; Mk. 14:36; Lk. 22:42

And submission to God's will is never manifested so clearly as in days and hours of storm when in the midst of menacing and frightful waves the Christian gives himself totally into the hands of Him Whose very hand holds these waves and tempests.

When can the steadfastness, courage, and strength of a soldier of Christ be better demonstrated than when trials and obstacles must be turned into deeds, than in the war against evil, or in times of danger? All the noble strength of the Christian soul, of the Christian character shines forth most brightly in times of distress, misfortunes and sufferings. All the miracles of God's grace are most evident in times when the waters of grief and misfortunes flood our souls and we are forced to recognize our helplessness, our weakness and draw all strength and understanding from Almighty God.

Or, when God Himself chastises you and calls you to account, are you going to ask "what for" and "why"? Or when the Lord sends you to the school of the cross, will you say: "I have not need of its teachings"? Rather you must say: "I need this; I must go to this school of the cross; I must suffer with Christ in order to be raised with Him" [cf. Rom. 6:3-8; 2 Tim. 2:11-12]. When the Lord chastens me, I must think and feel like a child chastened by the loving right hand of the Lord, like a grapevine under the pruning shears of the gardener, like iron beneath the smith's hammer, like gold in the purifying fire. This "I must" is of God and I must not shrink from it.

If you, my friends, agree to what I say, here in the house of God, then hold onto this principle when you are visited by grief, and yours becomes the way of the cross. These are basic truths which must be repeated before each bed of sickness and with each student entering the school of sorrows. Pastors know this. He who preached these truths a thousand times to others must repeat them for himself in every situation. Thou, Lord, help us to understand more fully and to plant deep within ourselves this lesson of the divine "I must."

Even the ancient Greeks and other people bowed before the divine will, before sacred duty, before immutable destiny, man's dependence upon Providence. The submission of one's will before this divine "I must," the exact fulfillment of divine decrees – in the wise this was called wisdom, in heroes, it was courage, in the righteous, sanctity. How much more willingly must we Christians fulfill our duty when we know that we are not being led by blind faith, but by the good will of the Father which led even Christ to Golgotha and the Cross, but through Golgotha and the Cross to the glorious Resurrection. And so, we must put our faith and trust in Him even when we cannot comprehend the meaning of the guidance. Mankind would have been deprived of so much goodness, such glory and blessedness, if the Savior had harkened to the voice of Peter: 'defend yourself'.

Let each soul bow before the divine "I must;" for the will of God is good, perfect, guiding all men to salvation. And you, O son of dust and corruption, bend your neck under His almighty hand before which your strength is as nothing. Trust to divine wisdom before which your light is but a dark shadow. Give yourself over to the fatherly guidance of Him who desires not enmity and sorrows, but peace and blessedness for all mankind. When you submit your thoughts and your will to His thought and will, then no cup will be for you too bitter, and no cross too heavy. You will be able to withstand it. Such is the will of God.

If your spouse, children, friends, and everyone you love surround you; if they try to persuade you to have pity on yourself, not to destroy yourself – do not look at their tears, do not listen to their pleadings. Point to the Heavens and say: "Do not burden my heart; thus, it is pleasing to God and I must. You are reasoning according to man's wisdom and not God's." And if from your own heart there cries out the voice of flesh and blood, and

begins to persuade you: "...this cannot happen to you; defend yourself..." – turn away from this counsel of your own heart and follow after that which glorifies God.

We can more easily bear our afflictions if we keep in mind the example of the Savior. See with what peaceful and holy determination He goes to His Passion. And then follow Him along the path of the cross until with His last breath you hear from His lips the divine words:

It is finished.

Jn. 19:30

And then ask yourself: are not you inspired by this example? Do you not understand now the commandment: "...he who wishes to follow Me, let him deny himself, take up his cross and follow after Me?"

Mt. 16:24; Mk. 8:34; Lk. 9:23

Do you not share the conviction of that disciple who said: "I cannot wear a crown of roses when my Savior is wearing a crown of thorns"?

At the cross of Christ even the most suffering souls among us can find consolation. I have endured, and even now endure much, but my Divine Savior endures still more.

And if you find this example too lofty, read what the holy Apostle Paul says:

Thrice was I beaten with rods; once was I stoned, thrice I suffered shipwreck, a night and a day I have been in the deep; in journeyings often, in perils of waters, in perils of robbers, in perils in the city in perils in the wilderness, in perils in the sea, in perils among false brethren; in weariness and painfulness, in watchings often, in hunger and thirst, in fastings often, in cold and nakedness.

2 Cor. 11:23-30

See what he endured for Christ's sake, how many times he was beaten, stoned, imprisoned, and then understand how far we are from him. Everywhere the cross is the sign of Christianity.

A Christian cannot be without his cross. Amen.

The Cross

IN THE prophet Ezekiel (9:6) it is said that when the Angel of the Lord was sent to punish and destroy the sinning people, it was told him not to strike those on whom the "mark" had been made. In the original text this mark is called "tau," the Hebrew letter corresponding to the letter "T", which is how in ancient times the cross was made, which then was an instrument of punishment.

And so, even then was foretold the power of the Cross, which preserves those who venerate it. Likewise, by many other events in the Old Testament the power of the Cross was indicated. Moses, who held his arms raised in the form of a cross during the battle, gave victory to the Israelites over the Amalekites. He also, dividing the Red Sea by a blow of his rod and by a transverse blow uniting the waters again, saved Israel from Pharaoh, who drowned in the water, while Israel crossed over on the dry bottom (Exodus, chs. 14, 17).

Through the laying on of his hands in the form of a cross on his grandsons, Jacob gave a blessing to his descendants, foretelling at the same time their future until the coming of the "expectation of the nations" (Genesis, ch. 48).

By the Cross, the Son of God having become man, accomplished our salvation. He humbled Himself and became obedient unto death, even the death of the Cross (Phil. 2:8). Having stretched out His hands upon the Cross, the Saviour with them, as it were, embraced the world, and by His

blood shed on it, like a king with red ink, He signed the forgiveness of the human race.

The Cross of the Lord was the instrument by which He saved the world after the fall into sin. Through the Cross, He descended with His soul into hell so as to raise up from it the souls who were awaiting Him. By the Cross, Christ opened the doors of paradise which had been closed after our first ancestors had been banished from it. The Cross was sanctified by the Body of Christ which was nailed to it when He gave Himself over to torments and death for the salvation of the world, and it itself was then filled with life-giving power. By the Cross on Golgotha, the prince of this world was cast out (John 12:31) and an end was put to his authority. The weapon by which he was crushed became the sign of Christ's victory.

The demonic hosts tremble when they see the Cross, for by the Cross the kingdom of hell was destroyed. They do not dare to draw near to anyone who is guarded by the Cross.

The whole human race, by the death of Christ on the Cross, received deliverance from the authority of the devil, and everyone who makes use of this saving weapon is inaccessible to the demons.

When legions of demons appeared to St. Anthony the Great and other desert-dwellers, they guarded themselves with the Sign of the Cross, and the demons vanished.

When they appeared to Saint Symeon the Stylite, who was standing on his pillar, what seemed to be a chariot to carry him to heaven, the Saint,

before mounting it, crossed himself; it disappeared and the enemy, who had hoped to cast down the ascetic from the height of his pillar, was put to shame.

One cannot enumerate all the separate examples of the manifestation of the power of the Cross in various incidents. Invisibly and unceasingly there gushes from it the Divine grace that saves the world.

The Sign of the Cross is made at all the Mysteries and prayers of the Church. With the making of the Sign of the Cross over the bread and wine, they become the Body and Blood of Christ. With the immersion of the Cross, the waters are sanctified. The Sign of the Cross looses us from sins. "When we are guarded by the Cross, we oppose the enemy, not fearing his nets and barking." Just as the flaming sword in the hands of the Cherubim barred the entrance into paradise of old, so the Cross now acts invisibly in the world, guarding it from perdition.

The Cross is the unconquerable weapon of pious kings in the battle with enemies. Through the apparition of the Cross in the sky, the dominion of Emperor Constantine was confirmed and an end was put to the persecution against the Church. The apparition of the Cross in the sky in Jerusalem in the days of Constantius the Arian proclaimed the victory of Orthodoxy. By the power of the Cross of the Lord, Christian kings reign and

will reign until Antichrist, barring his path to power and restraining lawlessness (Saint John Chrysostom, Commentary on 11 Thes. 2:6-7).

The "sign of the Son of Man" (Matt. 24:30), that is, the Cross, will appear in the sky in order to proclaim the end of the present world and the coming of the eternal Kingdom of the Son of God. Then all the tribes of the earth shall weep, because they loved the present age and its lusts, but all who have endured persecution for righteousness and called on the name of the Lord shall rejoice and be glad. The Cross then will save from eternal perdition all who conquered temptations by the Cross, who crucified their flesh with its passions and lusts, and took up their cross and followed their Christ.

But those who hated the Cross of the Lord and did not engrave the Cross in their soul will perish forever. For "the Cross is the preserver of the whole universe, the Cross is the beauty of the Church, the Cross is the might of kings, the Cross is the confirmation of the faithful, the Cross is the glory of angels and the scourge of demons" (Octoechos: Exapostilarion, Monday Matins)-

A true story of the power of the Cross:

This story happened before my eyes. A friend asked me to become his son's godfather. I gladly agreed. Beck was 10 months old. He was such a cheerful and calm child that his father said: "It seems he does not feel any cold or pain. A real warrior in growing!"

After the baptism, Beck was put to bed. After some time, his mother said: "When I changed his clothes, I took off the cross, and forgot to put it on." I immediately got up and suggested: "I'm his godfather - let me put the cross on the child!"

I very carefully put a cross on my godson. He immediately woke up and cried - so much so that the crying turned into hysterics.

I went into the bedroom. The child was fast asleep. I very carefully put the cross on him. Beck immediately woke up and cried. At the cry his mother came into the room. Whatever she did: she rocked and gave him

milk, she could not calm him down. Crying went into hysterics. A frightened father came in, took his son in his arms, but the baby did not calm down.

Then he took him into the guest room and laid him on the table. The child immediately stopped crying and smiled.

"Now do you understand what he wanted," the father asked.

"Yes, he wanted to be with us," I answered.

No sooner had I finished, than there was a noise and the whole house shuddered. A cloud of dust flew from the bedroom. We looked in there. Exactly over the Beck's bed the ceiling had collapsed. Huge pieces of plaster lay on his bed and around on the floor. The grace of the newly-worn cross forced the child to cry and thereby saved him.

Orthodox Parables and Stories

Statement of Archbishop Peter on the Continuing War in Ukraine

Diocese of Chicago and Mid-America

March 3/16, 2022 Martyrs Eutropius and those with him

Statement on the continuing war in Ukraine

With the war in Ukraine continuing, we must raise our voice once again for the good of the souls of those entrusted to our spiritual care.

In war civilians should be protected to the greatest extent possible. According to the media, this war is being conducted immorally by only one side. This is never the case. We call both sides to cease military actions immediately.

Our priests report that they are hearing discussions to stop commemorating Patriarch Kyrill. In essence, this is schism, a sin that St. John Chrysostom says is not washed away even by the blood of martyrdom.

Patriarch Kyrill is in a very difficult and delicate situation, since his flock is on both sides of the war. He has called all parties during Great Lent to increase their prayers for peace.

Metropolitan Onuphry has stated that the evil of war is the rendering of the unity of the people, and the institution of hatred where there should be Christian Love. May his words ring in the ears of all who make decisions in this war.

We support the Metropolitan unconditionally.

We also hear from our priests that it has become difficult to keep the faithful united.

The Church from its inception has valued only truth above unity, and we must, as Orthodox Christians, strive with increased zeal during times of strife (be that war, pandemic, politics, or any divisive societal occurrence), to remain united. We must refocus ourselves on drawing nearer to God, cementing the unity within our parish communities.

A parish is a worshipping Eucharistic community: the people and the clergy united around the Holy Altar, partaking of the one Eucharist, drawing nearer to each other as a parish family and, thus, drawing nearer to God.

It is understandable that the faithful, being influenced by the society in which they live, and seeing that their hierarchs do not necessarily respond in a way that the society and media instruct, are confused. We understand this, but call upon all to renew their prayers that we, your hierarchs, would make the best decisions possible for the salvation and good of all.

We must be very clear: this is not a question of Russian nationality vs. Ukrainian nationality. There is no discrimination of peoples with God. In His eyes there is no favored nation. All are equal.

The Russian Orthodox Church Outside Russia (ROCOR) is an autonomous (self-governing) part of the Russian Church, and we serve the needs of all Orthodox peoples throughout the world who come to us. The

Church is on the side of neither Russia nor Ukraine, the Church is on the side of God.

We call upon all to hearken unto the words of the Great Litany, intoned at the beginning of each Divine Liturgy: "For the peace of the whole world,

for the good estate of the Holy Churches of God, and for the union of all, let us pray to the Lord!"

In Christ, +Archbishop Peter

https://www.chicagodiocese.org/news_220319_1

Statement of the Diocesan Council of the Mid-American Diocese

Call for Prayer – Cease Fire Negotiations

On February 15/28, 2022, cease fire talks were held by both sides in the war in Ukraine, and these talks are ongoing. We call the faithful children of our Mid-American Diocese to renewed prayer for success of these talks and a speedy end to the invasion.

War is, by its very nature, difficult to understand in its entirety. Things change quickly. The media takes part as an arm of the warring parties rather than as a benign entity seeking to inform those outside the war zone. The Church, along with all the people of the world, struggles to understand what is happening in this confusing context.

There has been criticism of the Church's public response to the crisis. On one hand this is understandable from a psychological point of view. People are emotional. They are hurt. They are frustrated. We want to blame someone. To attack. To somehow take part in bringing the war to an end, and we spread these attacks wherever we can. This emotional stress is understood by those who are on both sides of the war, and they use our struggles in this regard for their own purposes. Prayer is criticized as something empty – words that mean nothing. If we believe that is the case – that prayer is nothing but emotional emptiness – then we must indeed criticize all that call for such a response. But if we are Orthodox Christians, and we understand that prayer is real, that God can fix problems in the world that man, being the creation and not the Creator, cannot solve, then criticizing calls to prayer is frankly illogical and even contrary to our faith, and to the goal of changing war to peace.

It is important to understand that the Church will not critique any situation in the same sort of "real time" that the 24-hour news cycle provides to the world. The Church was founded for the salvation of mankind. It does not have a party other than Christ. It does not engage in propaganda, and furthermore, strives to avoid being used in the service of propaganda. Rather, the Church must maintain a space above any conflict, calling mankind to raise itself above the world (in this case, above war to peace), so that it can use this high road to show a path to salvation for all mankind, and especially to parties engaging in war. It is unrealistic to expect the Church to react in any other way, because the Church reacts as

it always has: carefully, with prayer and reflection, weighing the actions of the world against the Gospel, so that it is not calling its children to an emotional roller coaster of reaction to this, now to that, now again to this, etc., but calling its children to peace, prayer, and what is most effective for their salvation.

This is not to say that the Church cannot act. It can. And it must. And it does. On Sunday in our Mid-American Diocese a collection in support of the refugees from the present war was taken. Tens of thousands of dollars was raised. This is something to be thankful for, but also insufficient for the immeasurable humanitarian needs of those who are suffering from the invasion. In this regard, we will continue taking a collection each Sunday of the approaching Great Lent in our diocese. All funds will be conveyed to the one person beyond reproach in this conflict, His Beatitude Metropolitan Onuphry.

Hieromartyr Ignatius of Antioch writes: "Where the bishop appears, let the people be also, as where Jesus Christ is, there is the Church". It is the responsibility of the hierarchy to be the voice of the Church in her caring for the souls of the children of God. The Church is holy and sinless, but is a Divine Human organism by God's design. The faithful of the Church are not without sin and may err. But the Church does not harbor malice on any level and always preaches love for all – even for those who hate us, according to the very words of Jesus Christ. We call those who are engaged in criticism of the Church's response to share with us, in a positive way, how we might better serve God and man during this time. But we also call all to prayer. Prayer is real. The Lord can solve problems we cannot. If we pray more and bicker less we can have hope that the present war will end more quickly than it otherwise would, and this, in the end, is what matters.

https://www.chicagodiocese.org/news_220307_1

A Lenten Address from Bishop Irenei on the Diocese's Response to the Situation in Ukraine.

28 MARCH 2022: My very reverend and reverend fathers, pious monastics and faithful of the God-preserved diocese of Great Britain and Western Europe: As the terrible war in Ukraine carries on now into another sorrowful month, with blood continuing to water the soil on which our saints have trod and injustice dividing peoples whom God has called into unity, I wish once again to express my gratitude before God for the spirit with which the faithful and pious children of this Diocese have been, and are, responding to this unwanted and utterly lamentable war.

We as Orthodox Christians stepped into the present season of Great Lent with unusually heavy hearts, burdened by the weight of unsought-for bloodshed and war. Here in Europe, the grief of this suffering is close to home, both geographically, since Ukraine is so close to the territory of our diocese, but even more so spiritually, since our brothers and sisters in the long-suffering lands of Ukraine are precisely that: our brothers and sisters, and our mothers and fathers, and our children, not only in the general sense of the common bonds of all humanity, but in the sense of the spiritual kinship of our Orthodox faith. We are children of a common God, venerating common saints, partaking of the Holy Mysteries from the one

chalice of Christ's Church; and we look into each other's eyes and say with full sincerity the words of Ruth, recorded in our holy Scriptures: *'Entreat me not to leave you or to return from following you; for where you go I will go, and where you lodge I will lodge; your people shall be my people, and your God my God'* (Ruth 1.16).

The sorrow we are feeling — that our brother's blood is shed, that our sister's home is in ruins, that children suffer and grieve — adds a new pain to this season of repentance by which we prepare for the Lord's Resurrection. The Church, by her nature, calls always for peace; and in moments where peace is stolen by acts of violence and fratricidal bloodshed, we are reminded only too potently of our Savior's words: that the peace the world gives, which so easily crumbles under hatred and anger, is not the same as the peace He brings, and which we always seek. The Church is not a political enterprise, called to speak politically; and though there are those who persist in seeking political commentary from the Church, our charge is to speak, rather, of the spiritual realities beneath all world events, and here the reality is clear: we are experiencing wickedness, and the Christian must respond with the witness of a higher

way — and the actions to aid those who are grievously suffering so unjustly.

I wish to express my deep gratitude to the faithful of our Diocese, who in these weeks since the advent of this lamentable situation have responded with an immense outpouring of Christian love and work towards that peace. Centered in London but spreading throughout eleven countries and principalities of Western Europe, our Diocese of the Church Abroad has shown itself blessed with pious believers who, without hesitation, have seen the wounded, and rushed to heal their wounds; have witnessed the grieving and sought to provide consolation; have seen those in need, and raced to provide what is necessary. Our parishes, some of which are very large but many of which are very small, have raised many tens of thousands of pounds, euros and Francs — most of this coming forth in a matter of days, and sent directly to the humanitarian fund of His Beatitude Metropolitan Onuphry of Kiev and All Ukraine, head of the Ukrainian Orthodox Church and our beloved father, shepherd and witness to the peace of Christ — a man who stands with his flock, caring with all his heart for the Ukrainian people, and working to aid all those now in peril and need. And our parishes have organized so many other means of help, and so swiftly: from small communities organizing bookstalls to raise funds for refugee relief, to parishes offering shelter in the homes of parishioners for refugees arriving from Ukraine, to parishes organizing legal aid to assist refugees in obtaining legal status in European nations as they seek safety, to collecting medicines and clothes, and so many other acts of charity and love. May God bless all of you who have turned love into action; and those of you who are proving tireless in this necessary work.

My brethren, for more than a century our Church Abroad has been the home to Orthodox Christians across the world, with many of its parishes, through our heritage in the long history of Orthodoxy as a whole, having been functioning in places like London and Vevey and Geneva and Florence and elsewhere since long before the advent a century ago of our Church Abroad in her autonomous life and administration, which we preserve even today, headed by our Holy Synod and First Hierarch, His Eminence Metropolitan Hilarion of Eastern America, centered in New York. Linked to no State or government except as citizens of the many nations in which we dwell, these parishes, and this diocese — like all our dioceses across the world — embrace within them Orthodox Christians of every nationality and

race and tongue, without reference to political borders or affiliations. It is for precisely this reason that our faithful so instinctively see the present situation not as one of ‘us and them’, but simply as being a grief for us all — and therefore a cause for our common love, action, and shared labors.

I urge all of you, above all, to pray to Almighty God that the bloodshed will cease swiftly, that those in civil authority who are responsible for governments and militaries will at once turn from the way of the sword, and that peace may be swiftly restored. Prayer is the chief tool of the Christian, and is powerful: wield it well! In every single one of our parishes, at every Liturgy, we offer liturgical prayers for the swift end to the bloodshed in Ukraine: ensure you do this also at home. And I urge you, also, to preserve in all ways the love and concord of our communities in these times of strain and heightened emotion. Do not let fear or grief or anger turn your hearts cold; for then our sorrow is only multiplied. Rather, continue to be what you are in truth: children of the God Who loves all, sharing and showing His love to all. In this moment, rest securely in the stability of the Church: she is Christ’s body, not a tool of political whims or a reed to be blown about by even the fiercest storms of world events — but the very rock on which we can stand firm in times of trial, since she exists to provide hope for the hopeless, comfort for the grieved, and joy to those in sorrows.

As we continue through Great Lent, guard peace in your own hearts, and attain it through the ascetic practices of the Church; for if it does not exist in the heart, we cannot share it elsewhere. Be true peacemakers: acquire the Spirit of peace within you through prayer and fasting and the Mysteries of Christ, and use the strength of that peace to work together to help those who now stand in such immediate need of care.

May God bless you. May He swiftly bring peace to Ukraine and her children, uniting the divided and healing the suffering; and may His glory be revealed even in these hard days, to the salvation of His beloved human race.

<https://orthodox-europe.org/content/lenten-update-ukraine/>

Archbishop Mark. Letter about the war in Ukraine

Dear in the Lord Fathers, Brothers and Sisters:

During these terrifying days when streams of blood merge with the flow of deceit and wickedness, we Christians cannot allow ourselves to submit to the spirit of war. The spirit of war is demanding. It requires us to divide into parties. It forces us to hate.

We Christians must understand: the wrath with which war burns is the wrath of hell. The enemy of God drinks in not so much human blood as human bitterness and division. The devil wants nothing more than to separate man from his neighbor, from the Church and from Christ.

This is nothing new. Before the beginning of Great Lent, during Cheesefare Week, the Lord cautions us: “And ye shall hear of wars and rumors of wars: see that ye be not troubled: for all these things must come to pass, but the end is not yet. For nation shall rise against nation, and kingdom against kingdom... And then shall many be offended, and shall betray one another, and shall hate one another... And because iniquity shall abound, the love of many shall wax cold... But he that shall endure unto the end, the same shall be saved” (Matthew 24:6-13).

Ahead of us lies the just Judgment, the all-encompassing Divine Judgment. Those who forget this judge others quickly and carelessly-and

this is already war, the ancient war of the devil against God. On whose side shall we stand?

This sermon is addressed to those who serve the Church, and to those who have newly come. The German Diocese is our local Church. Contained therein are priests and believers of various nationalities: Ukrainians, Russians, Belarussians, Carpatho-Russians, Jews, “Russian Germans,” migrants, and the local “native” Germans, Greeks, Moldovans, Serbs, Georgians, Poles, Czechs, Hungarians... Each of us loves our homeland. But the All-Merciful Lord united us, called upon us to establish Church life within this diocese, to the salvation of the present and future generations of Orthodox Christians in this nation. Here we must be the People of God, serving the One God.

If we allow this service to divide along national traits, we will commit a grave, most grave sin—the rending of the living, unified Body of the Church.

It is this rupture, this division that the prince of this world lusts after, and more persistently demands of us.

We recall that it was even demanded of Christ that He present Himself as a political leader and would destroy the occupiers. That He would separate Himself from the Roman invaders and would become the God not of all mankind but of a single suffering nation. And when He did not satisfy

them-as many, many thought at the time to be well-deserved and righteous political expectations and imperatives-we recall what those who made these demands did to Him.

Politics always presumes division into “us” and “them.” But the bloodless Sacrifice of Christ is made “in all and for all.”

If our hearts are in disagreement with the words “in all and for all,” then can we partake of Communion? Are we truly Christian?

Let us for a moment lift our spiritual gaze to the heavens. Let us think of the invisible angelic world. The bond with that world is particularly noted by the Church during Liturgy: during the Minor Entrance, the Cherubic Hymn, the singing of “Holy, Holy, Holy...”

But the angelic world is not enclosed by the walls of the church. Even in the heat of battle, under bullets and bombs, when it seems that hell reigns over everything, each warrior is accompanied by his own Guardian Angel, who tends to and protects the person, cares and suffers for him. Demons, the servants of the devil, strive through their hatred to destroy human bodies, and mainly, their souls. The Angels, as heralds of Christ, strive to save each soldier with their love, no matter which side he fights for. And this pain is felt for the mothers praying in church, the wives and sisters of the warriors, praying for the salvation and consolation of the warriors on both sides.

To what shall we open our hearts-to love or to hatred? Whose side are we on this genuine war?

If we are Christians, let us reject the spirit of war which is alien to Christ.

May peace take hold in our hearts-that sole genuine peace which the Savior brought to us already.

Let us follow the Apostle’s call: “Neither give place to the devil... rather... labor, working with his hands the thing which is good, that he may have to give to him that needeth. Let no corrupt communication proceed out of your mouth, but that which is good to the use of edifying, that it may minister grace unto the hearers. And grieve not the holy Spirit of God, whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption... Let all bitterness, and wrath, and anger, and clamor, and evil speaking, be put away from you, with all malice: And be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ’s sake hath forgiven you” (Ephesians 4:27-32).

Let us firmly trust in the words of Christ:

“These things I have spoken unto you, that in me ye might have peace. In the world ye shall have tribulation: but be of good cheer; I have overcome the world” (John 16:33).

Amen.

Commemoration of the Dead Saturday March 6/19, 2022

+ Mark, Metropolitan of Berlin and Germany

[Saints Sergius and Herman of Valaam Monastery](#)

Archimandrite Zacharias Zacharou answering a question concerning the current situation in the world :

Q:What should we keep in mind and do in the current political situation?

A: We do not know everything about the conflicts of this world, nor is it necessary to know. We just pray with a compassionate heart for the peace of the world and for all. We do not take sides, because each side will be responsible for crimes, and we do not want to share in these crimes and be condemned. If we pray for those who are more wrong than right, well, we perform the commandment to love even enemies. And if we pray for those who are more right than wrong, we do well. Therefore, we cannot go wrong if we pray that God save all and grant peace to the world.

Especially for us, priests and monks, it is very important not to be political at all, because we offer our sacrifice to God, the Holy Liturgy, for the whole world; and if we are for some and against others, our sacrifice is annulled. I think that when there is a war, the best is not to be judgmental, but to have compassion and pray that the Lord may spare all from suffering. If my Liturgy is to have any value, no one should be missing from my heart when I stand before the altar of God and say to Him, ‘Thine own of Thine own, we offer unto Thee, in all and for all.

About the Spirit of Our Time, by Patriarch Pavle

Dear spiritual children, we live in difficult times of globalization, in times of trampling on basic human rights - human rights to life, the right of the child to be born, the right of parents to raise and care for their child, the right of a mother to be a caring mother to her husband, the right of a man to be a man! A monstrous globalist civilization is being created according to perverted morals, without the yeast of the eternal meaning of human life. Such a civilization, as long as it is contrary to the risen Christ and his gentle teaching, cannot survive.

With that in mind, let us be wise and careful as we approach the unhealthy table of this world’s offerings. Let us choose from it only that which is valuable for Christ and worthy of our vocation and dignity. Let us reject everything pseudo-civilizational, twisted and inhumane, just as Christ rejected the offer of the tempter on the Mount of Temptation: if you worship me, all that you see will be yours! We know the right answer: It is written: serve God only and worship Him alone! +Patriarch Pavle of Serbia of blessed memory

Simple Prayer

It is very important for a person to be aware of his weakness and be sincere in his relationship with God. For example, say to God: “Lord, forgive me, it’s boring and difficult for me to pray.” The Lord loves sincerity, conscientiousness, and responsibility of a person very much. But very often we go to God not as we are, but by putting on a lot of expensive clothes from our excuses.

As we know, Adam and Eve lost Paradise not because they sinned, but because they began to make excuses. Elder Paisios says terrible words: he who constantly makes excuses has a demon as his elder. When we turn to God with such words: “Lord, it’s hard for me to pray because my wife is not

listening to me, because my colleague lied to me, because the children do not obey me, and the like,” we put the responsibility on everyone but ourselves.

Some saints said something quite similar: “The world is bad because I am not good. When I become good, the world will be corrected.” A good God expects from each of us not what we cannot, but what we are able to do. The Lord will not demand from us what He did not sow. He will not ask a lame person why he did not become a sprinter, an illiterate person why he did not become a writer. The beginning of spiritual life is self-correction, it is “the creation of a factory of good thoughts,” as Elder Paisios said.

Those who come to the Holy Mountain for holiness find holiness, those who come to see nature find beautiful views. Everyone who comes to the Holy Mountain finds what he was looking for.

If I come to Moscow, I ask where the monasteries and temples are, and another asks where are the entertainment centers, discos, and so on. A person is looking for what is akin to him. If we put on black glasses, we will

see everything in black, green - in green, red - in red. If I am a crafty person, then I will see everyone as crafty; if I am kind, I will see everyone as good; if I am a suspicious person, then I will suspect everyone. - Archimandrite Arseniy (cell of Belozerka)

Saint Ascension" answers prayers ... if you are holy.

(A Beneficial Tale of St. Paisios the Athonite)

I remember an elderly monk at Esphimenou Monastery on Mount Athos, who was so simple that he thought "Ascension" was the name of a women Saint. He prayed to her on his komboschini, "Saint of God, intercede for us!"

Once, he had to feed a sick Brother in the infirmary and had nothing to offer him. He immediately went down the stairs, opened a window overlooking the sea, stretched his arms out, and said, "Ascension, my Saint, give me a little fish for the Brother." And right away, as if by miracle, a big fish jumped out of the sea and into his hands. The others who saw him were astonished, but he simply looked at them smiling, as if he were saying, "What's so strange about what you've just seen?"

And then look at us. We may know everything about the life and martyrdom of the Saints or about when and how the Ascension took place, and yet, we cannot even catch a tiny little fish! These are the strange and paradoxical things of the spiritual life, which the reasoning of those intellectuals that are centered on themselves and not on God cannot explain because their knowledge is of this world and sterile; their spirit is ill

with secularism, and their mind void of the Holy Spirit. [Source:](#) From *Spiritual Counsels, Volume 1: With Pain and Love for Contemporary Man by Elder Paisios of Mount Athos* (Holy Monastery "Evangelist John the Theologian," 2006), p. 230.

I am always talking about reading the lives of the saints, and I follow my own instructions. I'm amazed by the things that resonate in my soul when I read the lives of the saints. Sometimes little instructions occur that I would not otherwise anticipate. I think the lives of the saints give us an example of things we should be flexible about and things we should not be flexible about. How will we know which things? There is the rub, isn't it? We will know which things if we have the wisdom of God within us, and this is only possible if we live in holiness. That's a tall order for us; let's all try!

From: A letter from Priest Seraphim. Sunday of the Fathers of the First Ecumenical Council. May 23/ Jun 5, 2022

May 2, Saint Boris-Michael, Tsar of Bulgaria. We must be flexible *and* inflexible.

The life of this saint, who was a sovereign, a monk, and a soldier, is challenging to our modern sensibilities. This is especially challenging because of the political climate that we are in regarding war. And, to be absolutely frank, it is especially challenging considering the political climate, the propaganda, and distortions in the media and among the clergy regarding the war in Ukraine.

I want to present his life to challenge us. Unlike some commentators, I don't think that I'm a seer of mysteries and know all things, including the motivation of everyone who engages in a war or all of the guilty or innocent parties. God reveals these things as history evolves, and in some cases, not until the end of time.

Let's look at the life of Saint Boris/Michael. He was brought up a pagan, but he was instructed in the Christian faith in his childhood. When he took power in Bulgaria, he turned first to the Latin missionaries, but he realized that there was something "off" about them, and he turned to the Byzantine emperor Michael the Third for baptism. When he was baptized, he took the name of the emperor. A large number of boyars and the upper class were converted, and St Photios of Constantinople sent a letter to the Tsar telling him how a Christian ruler should live. Missionaries were sent, and eventually bishops from Constantinople. Over time, the entire country was baptized, and churches were everywhere.

His baptism was in 864, and by 888, only 22 years, he had grown tired of the worldly life of being a sovereign, and he renounced his throne and

retired to a monastery. But unfortunately, as is the case so often, great men sometimes do not have great children, and his oldest son Vladimir wanted to turn to the Latin missionaries, who were infected with the filioque heresy and the hegemonic pretensions of the Pope. Therefore, he laid aside his monastic garments and became a soldier again.

This is the challenging part. Some think that any violence whatsoever is absolutely unacceptable under any circumstances. In my experience, some people who think those things are also renovationists in ways such as being all in for LGBTQ stuff and even being the world calls oxymoronically "pro-choice." Of course, many do not hold those blasphemous views and still think that all use of force is completely unacceptable, but among some of those, they seem ready to follow whatever new thing is being promoted. The voice of the world is very loud! It is a certainty that we will hear that voice if we do not listen carefully to the shepherd's voice, which is stronger but softer. It seems that our history would dispute the claim that violence is never justified. We can know this only with hindsight.

From: A letter from Priest Seraphim. Sunday of the Fathers of the First Ecumenical Council. May 23/ Jun 5, 2022

Pentecost is a different kind of feast.

I'm writing this letter in the week after Pentecost. I've always felt Pentecost was one of the least "festal" of all of the feasts. It is one of the greatest feasts (I place it number two, after Pascha), but even on

the day of Pentecost itself, the church is thinking unlike other feasts, and in a very sober way. We spend very little time "basking" in the glory of the feast and get right to its application, almost right away.

On Pascha, everything is about the joy of Pascha and we maintain that energy until Ascension. Our fasting is nonexistent for all of Bright Week, and it is the easiest of all the year during the other days. We don't do prostrations in the church; we don't sing "O Heavenly King", which is a very penitential and compunctionate prayer. (My wife Marina sometimes proofreads my letters and finds a zillion mistakes! She also gives me some feedback which is good because when I write and don't get many responses, I am not really sure if I am "scratching an itch" or not. She disagrees with me that "O heavenly King" is a very compunctionate prayer. For her, it's like an anthem and is very inspiring and beautiful. I agree, but the end of the prayer and the contrast between it and the beginning is what makes it compunctionate for me. I'll have to save that for another letter.) We say "Christ is risen!" to each other, and sing it at the beginning of services instead of "O Heavenly King..."

After the Nativity of the Savior, we don't fast until the day before Theophany, and our services are continually reflecting on the impenetrable mystery of how the God who created the universe and is above the universe chose to humble Himself and become part of the universe in the flesh so we can become part of Him.

Things are different on Pentecost. The feast itself is one of the most visually stunning of the entire year. We cut the limbs of trees and have much greenery in the church. Green is my favorite color. I find it to be even more beautiful than the flowers of Pascha. But two things about the day of the feast show that we are thinking in a different way than is usual on a feast day.

The first is that we sing "O Heavenly King" three times during the vigil, and this is the first time whether at the church or at home (for those who understand the significance of this custom and observe it in their daily prayer) we will have said this prayer since Holy Friday. When we first say this prayer, we are all gathered together in the middle of the church, at the end of Vespers (actually the "Litya" service), and

everyone sings it together. My heart swells and I feel a deep sense of longing.

The prayer is asking for things that I'm not very good at, and it is telling me that these things can be accomplished. There is a deep sense of hope when I sing this prayer, and a longing to get better. Of course, we should always have a longing to get better, but as ephemeral beings, there are times when we focus more than other times, and in the church year, I am more aware of my failings, and my desire to be perfected, on the day of Pentecost than on any other day.

In many parishes, the Vespers for Holy Spirit Monday, called the "Kneeling Vespers" because we do some long prayers on our knees during the service, is served almost immediately after Liturgy. That makes for a very long day for those who are caring for children and the children themselves, and makes it difficult to fix food that's going to be hot and not overcooked. I find that to be rather exhausting, and for several years we have celebrated the service at 6 PM on Sunday evening, much like regular vespers.

This is a trade-off, of course. Some of those people that would've been there in the morning do not come to the evening service. But in my experience, if someone wants to be there, they will be, and if someone does not want to be there, it doesn't matter if I was handing out \$100 bills for participation.

From: Pentecost is a different kind of feast. Applying Pentecost by praying the Kneeling Prayers. A letter from Priest Seraphim. Sunday of All Saints (Sunday after Pentecost) June 6 / Jun 19, 2022

We always do what we **want to do. And Running with wolves.**

It always turns out that ***we do what we want to do***. The trick is that we should learn to ***want to do*** the things that are beneficial for ourselves.

Some people might argue with me about this. They would say that they don't want to sin and yet they still sin. My answer to that (I have a lot of experience, being a sinner and also a sinner who talks to a lot of sinners) is that most of the time the reason why we keep sinning is because we are ***not trying hard enough*** not to sin. It is always true that if we try hard to accomplish something, our desire for accomplishment is strong, and not trying hard is a sure sign that our desire is weak.

It takes a lot of effort to not sin. It takes prayer and prostrations and fasting and hard work. And if we don't want to do those things then, if we are honest with ourselves, we would admit that the sin that we say we don't want to do, we really ***want to do*** because we ***don't want to do*** the things that will strengthen us against that sin. Perhaps that syntax is a little complicated but put in a very simple way it is this: ***if we don't want to sin, we *will* want to do all the things that help us not to sin***. If we do not do all of those things, then we cannot honestly claim that we don't want to sin.

One of the "tricks" which will teach us to ***want to do the things that we should want to do*** is to immerse ourselves in the Christian life. We are already immersed in the secular life. Even if we do not seek it

out, there are false ideas around us all the time and toxic ways of life that we encounter every day.

I am reminded of a saying that my wife used to say to boys in +Daniel's Boy Scout troop. "If you run with wolves, you become a wolf." Sometimes in my cynical weakness, I feel that what I'm doing doesn't make a permanent impression. A lot of times it doesn't look like anything is really sticking. But that teaching made an impression. Recently one of Daniel's friends came to our house and showed some old pictures of the Boy Scout troop, and he related the saying, of which he told the first part to another friend of Daniel's, and this friend completed it. I'm glad they remember it!

It is a true saying. It applies not only to wolves but also to impious people, lazy people, and all the rest. If we hang around those that don't consider the faith to be important, then we will end up not considering the faith to be important. I guess another way of saying this is: "if you lay down with dogs you always get fleas."

The "friends" we must "run with" should be the saints and angels and the Theotokos. We should run with them through the services, reading the lives of the saints, the Bible, and other holy things, and prayer and prostrations. If we ***run with them***, we will learn to become like them. From: Pentecost is a different kind of feast. Applying Pentecost by praying the Kneeling Prayers. A letter from Priest Seraphim. Sunday of All Saints (Sunday after Pentecost) June 6 / Jun 19, 2022

It's absolutely impossible to become good unless we know that we are bad.

Whenever the Kneeling Vespers is celebrated, it is, in my opinion, the most compunctionate and focused Vespers of the entire year. Here we are on the day of the great feast, and we are praying for a long time on our knees with prayers that are full of compunction and longing and an *honest appraisal* of our sinfulness.

I love the honest prayers of Orthodoxy. There are people that don't like them because they are a little bit too honest for them. There are actually those who would say that our prayers are negative and show that we have a bad concept about ourselves. We have a *true concept* about ourselves. We are terrible sinners, and our hearts are full of darkness except when we are striving towards the light. And we don't do that all of the time. Those who have an honest concept of

themselves know that this is true. They also know that God will provide everything that is lacking as long as we are trying.

It is this dissonance between our behavior and the things that we say we believe that causes the soul a kind of sweet anguish. There is a certain pain in us, that makes us want to be better than we are. I personally love this feeling. It gives me energy and great hope. *It's impossible to get better at something if we don't know (or refuse to consider) we're bad at it.* I said this recently in the sermon: *"It's absolutely impossible to become good unless we know that we are bad."* The world doesn't want to hear this Gospel, and they hate it, but it is the Gospel of life. It is the gospel of joy. From: Pentecost is a different kind of feast. Applying Pentecost by praying the Kneeling Prayers. A letter from Priest Seraphim. Sunday of All Saints (Sunday after Pentecost) June 6 / Jun 19, 2022

Excerpts from the kneeling prayers

Excerpts, partial or entire, of the Kneeling Prayers From Vespers on the Evening of Pentecost

Useful for private prayer: For supplication and intercession for the living, For supplication and intercession for the dead and those in Hades, In the evening:

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/kneeling-prayers-of-pentecost-for-personal-prayer.doc> <http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/kneeling-prayers-of-pentecost-for-personal-prayer.pdf>

"O Most-pure, spotless, unoriginate, invisible, incomprehensible, unsearchable, immutable, invincible, immeasurable, forbearing Lord, Who alone hast immortality, Who dwellest in light unapproachable, Who hast made heaven and earth and sea, and all that is therein, Who unto all grantest their petitions before thy ask:

"We pray Thee and we ask Thee, O Master, Lover of mankind, the Father of our Lord and God and Saviour Jesus Christ, Who for us men and for our salvation, came down from the heavens and was incarnate of the Holy Spirit and the Ever-virgin Mary, the most glorious Theotokos; Who, having first taught in words, and afterwards instructed by deed, when He had endured the saving Passion, granted unto us, Thy lowly and sinful and unworthy servants a precept that we should offer prayers unto Thee, with bowing of the neck and knees, for our own sins, and for the errors of the people..."

Comment: The first two paragraphs of this prayer can be understood as a confession of faith, and a survey of the nature of God and the incarnation, like a compunctionate, more detailed explanation of the Nicene Creed. It should be studied carefully.

An important aspect of Orthodox prayer is that **our prayer is deeply theological and dogmatic**. For us, dogma is a living thing and not just facts. That God *is* and *all things* concerning his nature and the **dual nature of the God-man Jesus Christ** is for us first and foremost the *most important knowledge in the world*.

Our prayer is constantly suffused with expressions of these dogmas. Of course, dogma is no use whatsoever to the soul unless we change our behavior and it guides the way we live our lives.

"Accept us who fall down before Thee and shout: We have sinned; on Thee were we cast from the womb, from our mother's womb, Thou art our God.

"But inasmuch as our days were consumed in vanity, we were bereft of Thy help, we deprived ourselves of any defense; but presuming upon Thy compassions, we cry: The sins of our youth and ignorances remember not, and from our secret sins cleanse us, and cast us not away in the time of our old age, when our strength faileth; forsake us not even until we return again into the earth, vouchsafe us to return unto Thee; attend to us through Thy good favor, and grace;

measure our transgressions with Thy compassions, *set the abyss of Thy compassions against the multitude of our sins*.

"Look down from Thy holy height, O Lord, upon Thy people ... and looking for abundant mercies from Thee.

"Commit Thy people unto a faithful guardian angel, gather all into Thy kingdom, grant pardon unto them that hope in Thee; remit their sins and ours.

"Cleanse us by the working of Thy Holy Spirit; destroy the wiles of the enemy directed against us."

Comment: I hope these two examples show very clearly to you why I love these prayers so much. I hope that you will want to use them in your prayer, not just to hear them one day of the year, on the evening of Pentecost.

I love the honesty of these prayers and the intensity, and that they not only look at our own sins but show great care for everyone. I personally think that this prayer is excellent intercession to add to our morning or evening prayers. I sometimes replace a portion of my morning prayers with several of these prayers, while I am praying on my knees. I created a booklet (the link is above) with slightly edited prayers so that they are in context for any day and not just Pentecost.

Here is some "secret sauce" regarding our compunctionate prayer. It is always very intense and brutally honest about ourselves, at the same time being completely aware of the mercy of God. I love the line in the prayer above that says: *"set the abyss of Thy compassions against the multitude of our sins."*

We must always know with every fiber of our being that we have a multitude of sins, along with the equally certain knowledge that God loves us and desires that we be saved and that our *multitude of sins* cannot compare to His *abyss of compassions*. A healthy knowledge of this dogma does not enable a person to sin, with the idea that, after all, "God will forgive me", but instead it energizes a person to struggle more and to become better. Those who love this kind of prayer and live according to it know by experience that it is true. From: Pentecost is a different kind of feast. Applying Pentecost by praying the Kneeling Prayers. A letter from Priest Seraphim. Sunday of All Saints (Sunday after Pentecost) June 6 / Jun 19, 2022

The Ever-Memorable Metropolitan Hilarion

Metropolitan Hilarion reposed in the Lord on May 3/16, 2022 at 2 pm. I found out about his repose while at the monastery. He touched the lives of countless, literally thousands, and everybody has a Metropolitan Hilarion story to tell. He ordained me to the priesthood. He is a very kind and humble man, and he is a Christian first, and then a bishop. He was always very kind to me and he always remembered my name even though he only saw me perhaps a dozen times in this life. Please note that I'm talking about him and his personality in the present tense. Remember that he's only dead in the body but his soul lives. And we prayed for his soul the evening we found out about his repose. And you should also. I think that in his case our prayers for him will be very much to our benefit. I'm sure that there will be many stories that come out about Metropolitan Hilarion and I will try to pass some of them on, but I wanted to at least tell you a little bit about how to pray for him.

I guess I should first say why we should pray for him. I think he's among the blessed. But even if he's among the blessed, we pray for him until the church recognizes that he is among the saints. The church *recognizing* him as among the saints doesn't *put him in the ranks of the saints* (God knows many as His good and faithful servants whom we know nothing about) but we like to do things in good order. So, we pray for him with confidence and also with the quiet expectation that he will pray for us. We pray for him purely because he's not dead, and because of love. His body is dead but the soul is alive, and if we loved him in this life, we should love him when he is beginning the next life.

It is easy to pray for the reposed. You can say the Jesus prayer for the reposed, perhaps a certain number of times, such as 3 or 12 times, or an entire "rope" (such as a 100 knot prayer rope). You can do the Jesus prayer with a few prostrations for the reposed. You could say something like "Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy upon the servant of God Metropolitan Hilarion". You can also pray the prayer for the reposed that is found in many Psalters, or you can pray the prayer "O God of Spirits..." in your private prayers.

Perhaps my last suggestion might seem controversial to some because that is the prayer that the priest prays in requiem services. My opinion is that is no reason why you cannot pray such a beautiful prayer in your private prayers. A layman should never pray this prayer in the church, however. I have prayed this prayer literally thousands of times since my son +Daniel reposed almost 5 years ago (+06/11/2017), and the more I pray this prayer the more beautiful and energizing it is for me. I wouldn't want you to miss that blessing.

Here are some links:

<http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/prayer-for-the-dead+explanations-and-prayers.doc>

<http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/prayer-for-the-dead+explanations-and-prayers.pdf>

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/prayer-for-every-departed-person-in-the-psalter.doc>

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/prayer-for-every-departed-person-in-the-psalter.pdf>

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/prayer-for-the-dead-o-god-of-spirits-es.rtf>

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/prayer-for-the-dead-o-god-of-spirits-es.pdf>

Sin is our only adversary. Sin causes all evils.

I want to include for you an incredible sermon that we should read 100 times! And then we should live according to what we've read! We poor ones know so very little about the way to live our lives. We know so very little about what really causes our suffering and our sadness, our anxiety, catastrophes, death, destruction, and painful difficulties in life. The sermon makes the point which I will make less elegantly here, that everything that we perceive as evil has come about because of sin. It is sin, collectively and personally, culturally, of the city, country, the world.

I try very hard not to be political, but so I will chance a comment here. Anyone who blames the Ukrainian war on a particular individual or country does not understand sin. Sin causes all of our sufferings, and no one is free from it. Therefore, in war, there are many guilty parties. Even those that are originally innocent may become guilty because of sin. Again, I'm not making a political comment, and if you have a strong opinion that one or another group (or groups) of people or particular individuals is guilty and has caused this war, you're free to have your opinions, but if you do not understand that everything is happening because of the dark energy of sin, energy in which may influence you as much (or more!) as those that you blame, then you have not yet understood how dangerous sin is and how it is our only adversary.

St Ignatius will explain it much better than I can, however, I will have one more comment. There is a monastic custom that should be universal. That custom is to blame the devil or perhaps the passions, that is sin, when our brother sins against us. In other words, we do not blame our brother directly but recognize that sin is working in

him and we have compassion upon him because we are also sinners just like him. We are busy blaming each other or even whole countries, nationalities, and political parties when actually we should be blaming sin. Sin is something that we are well acquainted with, just as much as the sinners that we want to blame.

Let's try to have this custom. When your brother offends you should recognize that this offense has occurred for two reasons, both of which are because of sin. The first is that your brother is captive to a passion or sin and has acted out in a sinful way. Most likely, his captivity is one that you are aware of because you have personally experienced it. His actions have offended you or harmed you or made you angry. That is the second reason. Your offense because your brother has acted out because of sin is itself a sin. If we blame our brother, we sin, and sin increases sin. We are put into a vortex, from which we cannot escape without divine grace. If we blame our brother's sin, we naturally recall that we also share in that sin, or perhaps by the grace of God we no longer sin in that way but we have in the past, or perhaps we sin in a similar way or even a worse way. If we recall our own sin along with that of our brother, then we cause ourselves to willingly share guilt for the offense of our brother (we take on some of the burden of our brother), and we do not have personal animus towards our brother. Our anger is against sin, and not against our brother. It is not a sin to be angry against sin, but it is a terrible sin to be angry against those who sin.

Here's the sermon, below. I know it's long. Read it until you lose concentration and then take it up again. And then read it again.

HOMILY ON THE SUNDAY OF THE PARALYTIC ON DIVINE PUNISHMENT

BY St. Ignatius (Brianchaninov)

Source <https://orthochristian.com/35019.html>

Behold, thou art made whole: sin no more, lest a worse thing come unto thee (Jn. 5:14).

This is the commandment the Lord gave to the paralytic whom He healed, as we heard today in the Gospels. Beloved brethren! This commandment of the Lord has enormous importance for us. It teaches us that we are subjected to sickness and other catastrophes of this earthly life for our sins. When God delivers us from sickness or catastrophe but we return to a sinful life, we are again consigned to catastrophes that are more onerous than those which were our first punishments sent from God to bring us to our senses.

Sin is the cause of all man's sorrows, both in time and in eternity. Sorrows are the natural consequence, the natural property of sin, just as sufferings, produced by physical illnesses, are the unavoidable property of these illnesses, and their characteristic effect. Sin in the broad sense of the word could also be called the fall of humankind, or its eternal death, and encompasses all people without exception. Some sins are the sad inheritance of whole human societies. Finally, each person has his own individual passions, his own particular sins he has committed, that belong to him exclusively. Sin, in all these various forms, serves as the beginning of all sorrows and catastrophes to which all mankind is subjected, to which human societies are subjected, and to which each person, in particular, is subjected.

The state of fallenness, the state of eternal death, by which all mankind is infected and stricken, is the source of all other human sins, both societal and personal. Our widespread sin-poisoned nature has acquired the ability to sin and an inclination toward sin, it has subjected itself to sin, and can neither remove sin from itself nor do without it in any of its activities. A person who has not been renewed cannot help but sin, although he may not want to sin (Rom. 7:14–23).

There are three punishments determined by God's righteous judgment upon all mankind for the sins it has committed. Two of them have already happened, and one is yet to happen. The first punishment was eternal death, to which all mankind was subjected at its root — its forefathers — for disobedience to God in paradise. The second punishment was the great flood, which occurred because mankind allowed the flesh to overcome the spirit, and lowered itself to the dignity of irrational beings. The final punishment will be the destruction and end of this visible world for apostasy from the Redeemer, for people's ultimate deviation into communion with fallen angels.

Quite often, a particular kind of sin engulfs whole human societies and brings God's punishment down upon them. Thus, the Sodomites were consumed by fire that fell from the sky for their unlawful fleshly pleasure; thus, the Israelites were given over more than once to alien tribes for worshiping idols; thus, one stone was not left upon the other in magnificent Jerusalem, built of marvelous stones, and its inhabitants perished under the Roman sword for rejecting the Savior, and deicide. Sin is infectious; it is hard for individuals to resist the sin that ensnares entire societies.

In the long sickness of the paralytic healed by the Lord we see an example of punishment for the sins of one individual, who was likewise punished individually by God.

Having said as much as needs to be known and as much as can now be said about the sinfulness of the entire human race and human societies, let us direct particular attention to the personal sinfulness that every person has of his own. This observation is essentially needed and essentially useful to us. It can have a saving influence upon what we do, diverting us from the path of lawlessness, and directing us according to God's will. Enlightened by God's law, we learn that God in His unbounded mercy, Who is perfect in the righteousness of His judgment, will unfailingly render due punishment for a sinful life. This conviction incites us to apply all our strength towards freeing ourselves from the bondage to our own passions and the corrupt customs of society and to deliver ourselves from temporary and eternal Divine punishments.

The holy fathers^[1] say that before the time of their redemption, all people were possessed by sin; they did the will of sin even against their own will. After the redemption of mankind by the God-Man, those who believe in Christ and were made new by holy Baptism are no longer forced by sin, but rather have freedom — freedom either to resist sin, or to follow its suggestions. Those who willingly submit themselves to sin again lose their freedom, and are forcibly overcome by sin.^[2] Those who, guided by the Word of God, conduct warfare against sin and resist it, will eventually conquer sinfulness completely. Victory over our own sinfulness is at the same time victory over eternal death. He who obtains it will easily resist the sinful attractions of society.

We can see this in the lives of the holy martyrs: having conquered sin in themselves, they withstood the people's error, rebuked it, and did not hesitate to seal their sacred testimony with their blood. A person who is attracted and blinded by his own sin cannot but be attracted by society's sinful mode; he does not look at it clearly, does not understand it as he should, does not renounce it with self-denial, and his heart belongs to it. The essence of ascetical striving against sin, the work which every Christian is obligated to do, consists in the struggle against sin, in breaking friendship with it, in the victory over it in one's own soul, mind, and heart, to which the body is bound to be in sympathy. "Eternal death," says St. Macarius the Great, "is hidden in the heart; a person is dead through it, though he outwardly lives. He who has gone from death to life in the secret recesses of his heart will live for ages, and will never die. Although the bodies of such people may depart for a time from their souls, they are *sanctified*, and will arise with glory. For this reason, we call the death of the saints "sleep."^[3]

All the saints without exception (Heb. 12:8), regardless of their victory over eternal death and revelation of eternal life within themselves even during this temporal life, were subjected to many and difficult sorrows and temptations. Why is this? It is the nature of sinners to earn Divine punishment. Why then do God's elect not escape the Divine rod, which strikes them as well? According to the teaching of Holy Scripture and the fathers, this question is resolved

in the following way. Although sinfulness has been conquered in righteous people, although eternal death is destroyed by the presence of the Holy Spirit in them, they have not been given immutable goodness that would remain throughout the course of their earthly sojourn; the freedom to choose good or evil has not been taken away from them.^[4]

Immutable goodness belongs to the future age. Earthly life up until its final hour is a field of voluntary and involuntary ascetical labors. The Great [Apostle] Paul says, *But I keep under* [in Slavonic, “mortify”] *my body, and bring it into subjection: lest that by any means, when I have preached to others, I myself should be a castaway* (1 Cor. 9:27). The Apostle says this of a body salted and sanctified by Divine grace, a body uninjured by cruel venom, whose clothes produced healings. Even that body required enslavement and mortification, so that its mortified passions might not be revived and eternal death not be resurrected! Though he be a vessel of the Holy Spirit, eternal death can be resurrected in a Christian for as long as he wanders the earth, and sinfulness can again encompass his soul and body.

But the *podvig*^[5] alone of the servants of God is not enough to mortify the fallenness which nests in a nature that continually strives to regain its dominion; they need help from God. God helps them with His grace and fatherly punishing rod according to each one’s grace. The great [Apostle] Paul was given, as he testifies, *a thorn in the flesh, the messenger of Satan to buffet me, lest I should be exalted above measure* (2 Cor. 12:7)^[6] — because of his exalted spiritual progress, because of the many Divine revelations granted to him, because of the many spiritual gifts that he had, and because of the many miracles that he performed. Our nature is so injured by sinful poison that the abundance of God’s grace itself in a person can serve as the cause of his pride and destruction.

St. Paul met neither honor, nor glory, nor unquestioning obedience when he preached Christ to the universe, even proving the truth of his preaching through signs; an angel of Satan set his traps everywhere — resistance, humiliation, persecution, attacks, and death. Knowing that this all happens as God allows it to do, St. Paul exclaims, *Therefore I take pleasure in infirmities, in reproaches, in necessities, in persecutions, in distresses for Christ’s sake* (2 Cor. 12:10). St. Paul found it necessary to mortify his body, so that from a relaxed body fleshly passions would not arise; while the eye of God’s Providence saw the need to guard his soul from pride through sorrows.

The purest human nature has something of pride in it, as St. Macarius the Great noticed.^[7] For this reason, slaves of God subject themselves to voluntary deprivations and sorrows — at the same time, God’s Providence allows various sorrows and temptations to come upon them, supplementing the *podvigs* of His servants and preserving their *podvig* from the corruption of sin through sorrows. The path of earthly life has always been laborious, thorny, full of depravations, and laden with countless misfortunes. *Some*, says the Apostle Paul, *were tortured, not accepting deliverance; that they might obtain a better resurrection: And others had trial of cruel mockings and scourgings, yea, moreover of bonds and imprisonment: They were stoned, they were sawn asunder, were tempted, were slain with the sword: they wandered about in sheepskins and goatskins; being destitute, afflicted, tormented; (Of whom the world was not worthy:) they wandered in deserts, and in mountains, and in dens and caves of the earth* (Heb. 11:35–38).

Blessed Symeon Metaphrastes notes in the life of Great Martyr Eustathius: “It is not pleasing to God that His servants, for whom he has prepared eternal, permanent glory and honor in heaven, should abide as honored and glorified with vain and temporary honor in this transitory and unstable world.”^[8] Why is this? ***Because no man is able to abide at the heights of earthly magnificence and well-being without harm to his soul.*** Even one who is equal to the angels in his morality would be shaken.^[9] In us, in our souls, is planted through our fall the potential to revert. We cannot help but conform our spirit’s inclinations to our outward, material circumstances. *My soul hath cleaved to the earth*; (Ps. 118:25) confesses the prophet to God for every fallen person. *Thy right hand*, he says, “Thy all-holy Word, and Thy all-holy Providence lifts me from the earth, wrenches me from it, and leads me to salvation, dissolving my temporary well-being with sorrows, but consoling me with grace-filled consolations that breathe into my heart a yearning for heaven. Without this help from God, with my wretched inclinations against which I cannot stand by my own powers alone, I would cling in mind and heart to the material world, and would terribly, fatally deceive myself, forgetting about eternity, about the blessedness prepared for me in it, irrevocably losing it.”

The true servants of God accepted with submissiveness to God, with thankfulness, and glorifying God, all the sorrows that God’s Providence allowed to befall them. They accepted it willingly, as the Apostle Paul says, and were well-disposed towards their sorrows. They found them profitable, needful, necessary for themselves; they considered them to be correctly allowed, and beneficial. They united the yearning of their own will to the manifestation of God’s will; in the exact sense, they were well-disposed toward punishments and correction sent to them from God.

From just such a disposition of heart, from this kind of thinking did the saints look upon the catastrophes that befell them. Spiritual consolation and rejoicing, renewal of spirit, and a perception of the future age were the results of the disposition inspired by humility of mind. What will we sinners say of the sorrows that greet us? What, first of all, is their initial cause? The initial cause of human suffering, as we see, is sin; and any sinner does well who quickly turns his inner gaze towards his own sins when sorrows befall him, and accuses his sins, accuses himself for his sins, and accepts the affliction as God’s just punishment.

There is another reason for sorrows: the mercy of God toward feeble humans. By allowing sorrows to come upon sinners, God encourages them to come to their senses, to halt their uncontrollable longings, to remember eternity and their relationship to it, to remember God and their obligations to Him. Sorrows that are allowed to befall sinners serve as a sign that these sinners are not yet forgotten, not rejected by God, that their ability to repent, correct themselves, and find salvation is still being evaluated.

Sinners punished by God, take heart; For whom the Lord loveth he chasteneth, and scourgeth every son whom he receiveth (Heb. 12:6). Holy Scripture tells us this, instructing, consoling, and strengthening us. *Lay hold of instruction, lest at any time the Lord be angry, and ye perish from the righteous way* (Ps. 2:12); accept punishment with the awareness that you are deserving of punishment; accept punishment, glorifying the merciful God, Who is just in His righteous judgment; accept punishment with a dispassionate evaluation of the life you have lived, with confession

of the sins you have committed, with cleansing of your sins by tears of repentance, and correction of your behavior.

Often we need little outward correction, but very much correction secretly: correction of our kind of thinking, inclinations, motives, and intentions. You have diverged from the righteous path by your sins; do not lose it entirely by murmuring, by justifying yourself against your conscience before people, by hopelessness, despair, and blasphemy against God. Do not turn the means given to you, the means which the Lord Himself uses to redirect you to the path of piety, into a way to become completely undone, to wreak your own demise. Otherwise, the Lord will be angry with you. He will turn His face from you as from something alien to Him; He will withhold sorrows from you as from one forgotten and rejected (cf. Heb. 12:8); He will allow you to spend your earthly life in the lusts of your sin-loving heart, and will command death to cut you down unexpected, and you will be like the tares which made themselves the property of the fires of Gehenna by their own free will.

He who endures well all the temptations allowed by God comes closer to God, acquires boldness before Him, becomes familiar to Him, as the Apostle testifies: *If ye endure chastening, God dealeth with you as with sons* (Heb. 12:7). God fills with spiritual blessings the one who endures sorrows with humbleness of spirit, hears his heartfelt prayers, and often turns back the whip and rod of chastisement if it is no longer needed for greater spiritual progress.

This is what happened at the healing of the paralytic, who lay for thirty-eight years at Solomon's gate amongst a crowd of many other sick people who waited, like the paralytic, for the vivifying movement of the waters at the hand of the angel. Such a miserable condition is involuntary sickness and poverty! It is obvious that those sick people had no means to pay for doctors, and therefore they resolved to wait a long time for the miracle which occurred once a year, which brought sure and complete healing from any illness — but only to one sufferer. The sickness of the paralytic was punishment for sins, as is clear from the condition the Lord gave to the one He healed: *Behold, thou art made whole: sin no more, lest a worse thing come unto thee* (Jn. 5:14).

The Lord gave the paralytic this commandment, so that he would not fall again into the same sins for which he had been punished through illness, gave the same commandment to the sinful woman when He forgave her sins. *Go*, said the Savior of the world to a person whom the righteous of the earth had sentenced to stoning, *and sin no more* (Jn. 8:11). Healing of soul and healing of body is given by the merciful Lord under one condition — the same

condition. The woman's sin was a mortal sin; apparently the paralytic's sin also belonged to the category of mortal sins. These are the kind sins that most often call down God's punishment.

The one who has sunk into the abyss of mortal sins needs particular help from God — this help is manifested openly in punishment, and secretly in the call to repentance. A person is called to repentance either by sickness, as was the paralytic, or by persecutions from people, as was David, or by some other method. No matter what form God's chastisement takes, we should accept it with humility, and hasten to satisfy that Divine aim with which the punishment was sent: to have recourse to the cure which is repentance, having embraced within our souls the commandment to abstain from the sin for which the Lord's hand chastises us. Our own conscience will assuredly point out that sin to us. Forgiveness of the sin and deliverance from the affliction by which we are punished for the sin is granted to us from God, only under the condition that we abandon the sin so destructive to us, and so hateful to God.

A return to the sin that brought God's wrath down upon us, the sin that was healed and forgiven by God, is the cause of great catastrophes, most of which are eternal, beyond the grave. The paralytic languished thirty-eight years for his sin. It is a significant punishment! However, the Lord pronounces an even greater punishment for returning to sin. What punishment could be more onerous than the one which restrained the sick man all his life on his bed, amidst such depravations? Nothing other than the eternal torment in hell which awaits all unrepentant and incorrigible sinners. Amen

[1] Abba Dorotheus, homily 1.

[2] "Blagovestnik"; Mt. 12:44–45.

[3] Homily 1, chap. 2.

[4] St. Macarius the Great, Homily 7, chap. 4. St. Isaac the Syrian, Homily 1.

[5] *Podvig* is the untranslatable word denoting especial ascetical labor, effort, struggle.

[6] The entire passage reads, *And lest I should be exalted above measure through the abundance of the revelations, there was given to me a thorn in the flesh, the messenger of Satan to buffet me, lest I should be exalted above measure.* —Trans.

[7] Homily 7, chap. 4.

[8] Menaion, September 20.

[9] St. Isaac the Syrian, Homily 1.

[10] Ibid.

[St. Ignatius \(Brianchaninov\)](#) Translated by Nun Cornelia (Rees) 5/15/2011